Checking the Booth

John Smoltz's World Series Game 3 color commentary, tested claim by claim

Trent Reimers | 2026 World Series Game 3, MIL @ TB | October 29, 2026

The question. Whether a color commentator is good is a matter of taste. Whether what he says is true is not. So when John Smoltz says something about how baseball works, does the data back him up? My live notes from his World Series Game 3 broadcast logged 25 claims that data can check, and I wrote down a test and a pass rule for each one *before* I ran any numbers.

The short answer. Smoltz knows pitching and the old truths of the game; the storytelling lines hold up less well. Of 25 claims, 8 are supported and 3 partly, 11 find no support, 2 are contradicted and 1 cannot be called. On pitching and hitting craft he is right 9 times in 12. On momentum, carryover and "October is different" he is right once in 9.

What the data says.

1. **The pitcher in him is right.** Leadoff men matter (innings score 51% of the time when he reaches, 16% when he is out), walks cost nearly as much as singles, good fastballs hold up against fastball-hitting teams, elite stuff survives a mistake over the middle, and the zone is wider away than in.
2. **So is his read on swings.** Middle/opposite-field hitters whiff less, and Part 7 shows why: they swing flatter, and the flatter swing accounts for their whole whiff edge. The steep, launch-angle swing whiffs more, mostly up in the zone, but pays it back in barrels.
3. **The momentum lines don't show up in the data.** A clean first inning, an escaped jam, a blowout or a one-run loss, a streaky season: none of them moves the next inning, game or series once the score and team strength are known.
4. **October is not different in the ways he said.** Two-out baserunners, bullpens and 3-0 green lights behave as they do in the regular season.
5. **Two calls point the other way.** A correct ABS challenge is kept, so there is no reason to hold one when you are right: early challenges pay off above about 37% success and actually win 63%. And platooning against the starter does pay: the same hitter gains about 29 points of wOBA with the platoon edge, and stacked lineups chase the starter sooner.
6. **His read on Bauers was fair.** Jake Bauers swings at 3-0 about 2.0 times as often as the league, and in Game 3 he swung 3-0 in the 3rd. The early-inning sample is just too small to confirm the claim at the bar I set for it.

Coming in unbiased. I came in with my own opinions about the broadcast, like any viewer. I built the rules below to keep those out of the results, and every claim's write-up says where I changed a test after a first look.

How I kept it fair

- **Rules first.** Every claim got a test, a data window and a pass rule in `claims.csv` before its script ran. Where I changed a test after a first look, that claim's caveats say what changed and why.
- **Five verdicts, not two.** Supported, Partly supported, Not supported (no evidence either way at a usable sample size), Contradicted (the data points the other way) and Inconclusive (too little data to say). I left out opinions, advice and tangents.
- **The strongest version of the claim.** Broadcast lines are loose. I tested each one in the form Smoltz most plausibly meant, not the easiest form to knock down.
- **October where it matters.** A 12-team postseason gives about 40 games a year. I tested claims that are specifically about the playoffs on the postseason and compared them with the regular season of the same years. For claims about baseball in general I used all games, so a small October sample does not hide a real effect.
- **Accuracy is not the whole job.** A color commentator also explains, tells stories and fills quiet time. I scored the factual claims only.
- **Note-taking bias.** My notes record what I found worth writing down, so they likely over-sample the lines that stood out to me. The fix is a full transcript of the broadcast (closed captions), so every remark gets logged, not just the memorable ones.

What he said

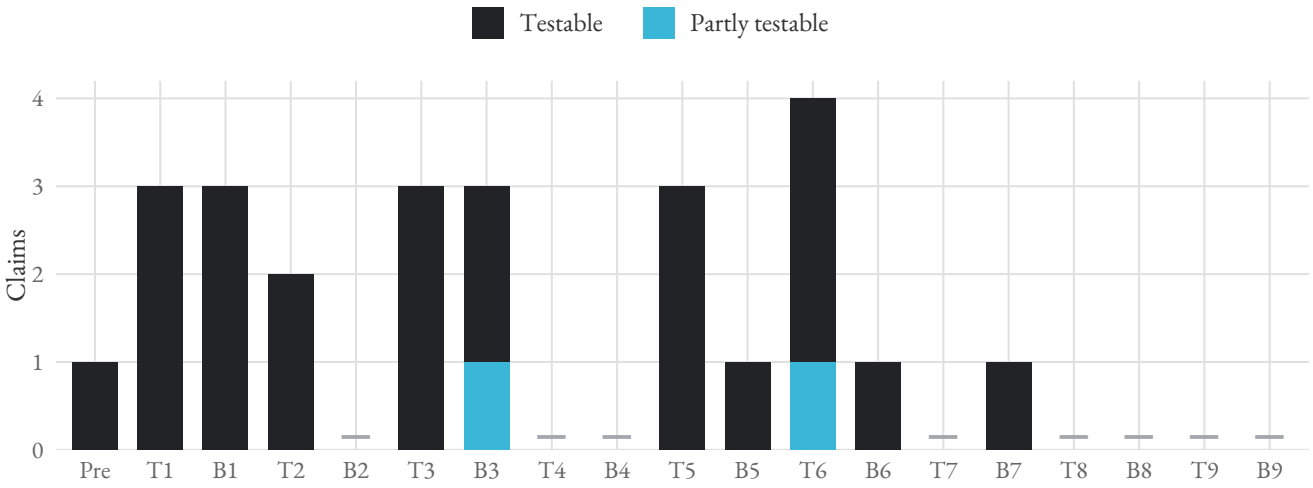


Figure 1: Smoltz claims logged per half-inning. Grey ticks mark half-innings with nothing logged from Smoltz. The zone remark under B6 was said earlier and written down then.

8 of 18 half-innings have no checkable claim logged from Smoltz. My own questions from the game (Freddy Peralta's approach angles, the 3-0 green light in October) are tested alongside but kept out of Smoltz's scorecard.

The scorecard

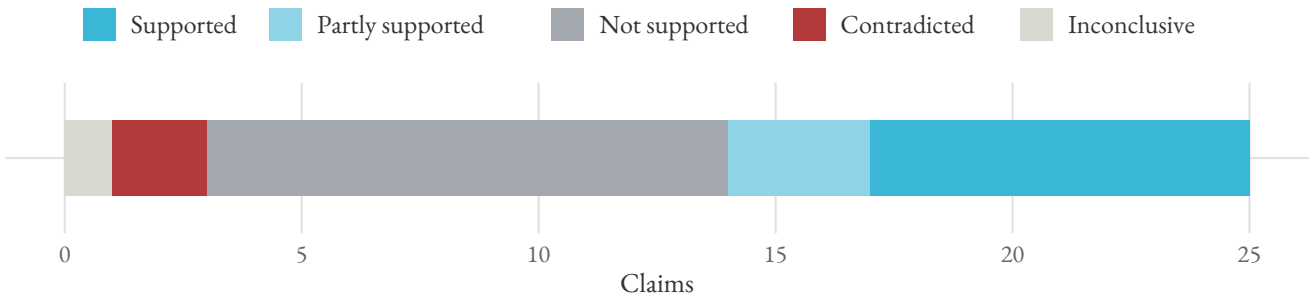


Figure 2: Verdicts on the testable Smoltz claims.

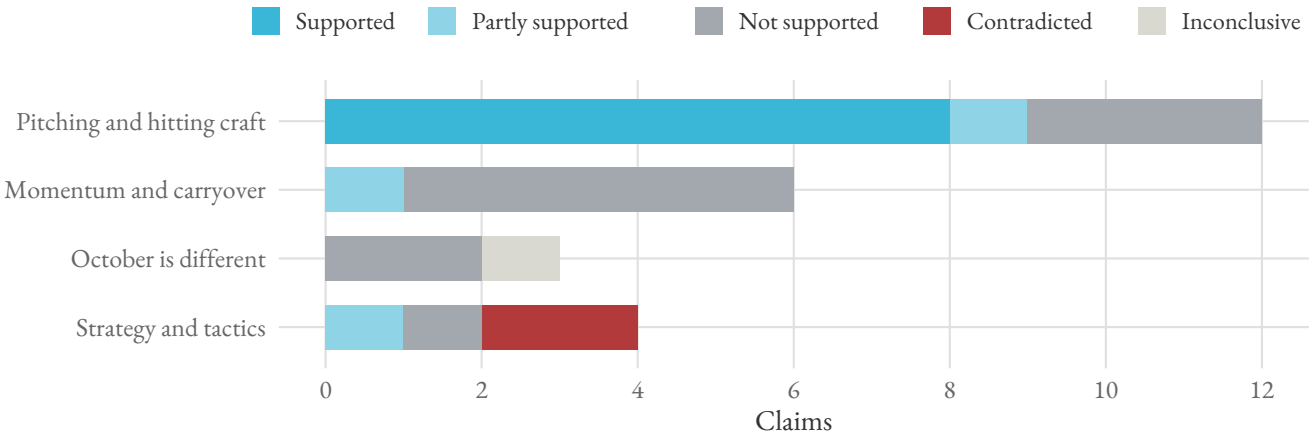


Figure 3: Verdicts by the kind of claim.

Table 1: Every scored Smoltz claim.

ID	Half	Claim	Verdict
C01	Pre	Baserunners, steals and two-out hits win postseason games	Inconclusive
C02	T1	The starter sets the temperature for the team in the first inning	Not supported
C03	T1	First-pitch strikes, retiring the leadoff man and avoiding three-ball counts keep runs off the board in the postseason	Partly supported
C04	T1	Don't be afraid to throw fastballs to a fastball-hitting team	Supported
C05	B1	Smoltz, anti-platoon: platooning against the starter does not pay; the Rays platoon to beat the starter early and shorten his outing	Contradicted
C06	B1	A slow runner in front of a fast runner cancels the speed	Partly supported
C07	B1	Pickoff throws split the pitcher's attention and help the hitter	Not supported
C08	T2	Non-competitive pitches kill pitch count	Supported
C09	T2	Get the leadoff hitter and the offense goes down	Supported
C10	T3	When a hitter is hot, make sure it's not down the middle	Not supported
C11	T3	Bauers will have the 3-0 green light early	Not supported
C12	T3	Walks will haunt you (1B-BB-1B vs three singles)	Supported
C13	B3	Lefty: sinker in to a righty sets up the changeup away	Not supported
C14	B3	Elite stuff gets results even when the ball goes where it wants	Supported
C15	B3	Don't use an ABS challenge early in the game, even if you're right	Contradicted
C16	T5	You have to beat the bullpens in the playoffs, especially good ones	Not supported
C17	T5	Escaping a mid-inning jam while trailing swings the game	Not supported
C18	T5	Two-out baserunners kill in the postseason	Not supported
C19	B5	A big loss without hitting carries over to the next game	Not supported
C20	T6	Positive regression on LOB in a seven-game series	Partly supported
C21	T6	The middle/opposite-field approach is the anti-launch-angle approach; the launch-angle approach leads to too much whiff	Supported
C22	T6	Three-two count: ball-four-or-base-hit mentality	Supported
C23	T6	Streaky teams don't succeed in the playoffs; you have to be steady	Not supported
C24	B6	The zone is more generous away than in, by batter hand (said early, noted in B6)	Supported
C25	B7	One-run losses hurt more than blowouts	Not supported

Part 1

Pitches and counts

Claims about pitching and hitting approach, tested pitch by pitch in Statcast. This is Smoltz's home ground.

First-pitch strikes, retiring the leadoff man and avoiding three-ball counts keep runs off the board in the postseason C03, top of the 1st

What was said. In the top of the 1st, with Peralta on the mound, Smoltz ran through the starter's checklist: get ahead with strike one, retire the leadoff man, stay out of three-ball counts.

How I tested it. I took every postseason start from 2020 to 2026 (543 starts with at least 9 batters faced) and measured each habit against that pitcher's own regular-season rate, so a pitcher who always pounds the zone is not credited for doing it again. Runs allowed per batter faced were regressed on the three habits together plus the pitcher's usual run rate, then scaled to runs per nine innings per 10 points of each habit. The same model on August-September regular-season starts says whether October is special.

Right if. Each habit, above the pitcher's own norm, lowers runs allowed (CI excludes zero). Report size and whether October differs from September. *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

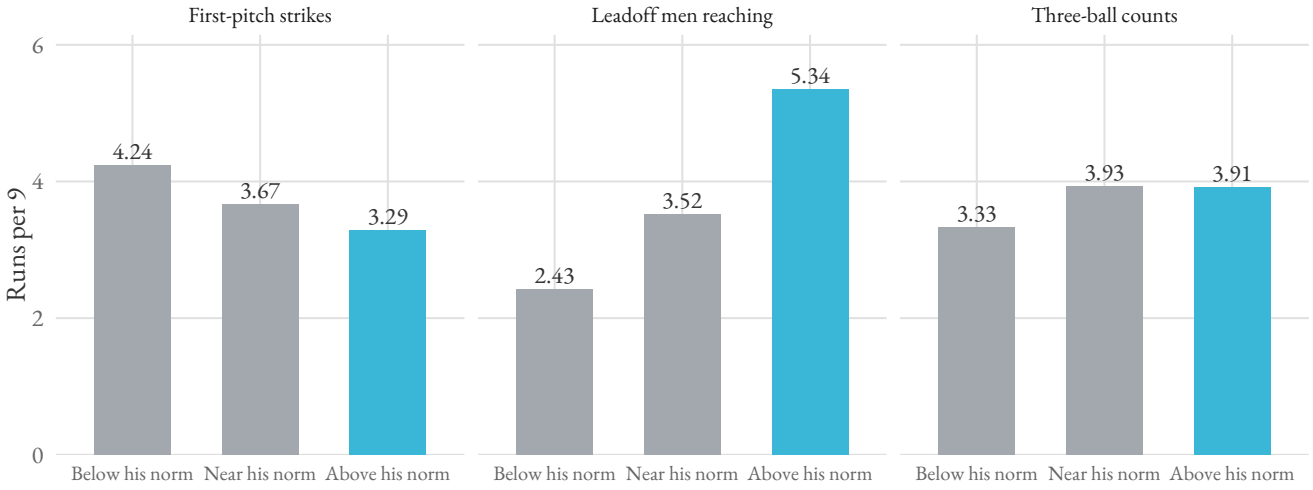


Figure 4: Postseason starts 2020-26, runs per 9 innings by how each habit compared with the pitcher's own norm (thirds of starts).

What I found. Two of the three habits carry real weight in October. A start with more first-pitch strikes than the pitcher's norm allows fewer runs, and the effect is larger than in the late regular season. Leadoff men reaching is the strongest of the three, but part of that is mechanical: a leadoff man on base is already a step toward a run. Three-ball counts, once the other two are in the model, add nothing on their own.

Caveats. Pitchers are not assigned their habits at random: a sharp day produces both strike one and few runs. That makes this a description of good starts more than proof that the habits cause them. The postseason sample is small (about 180 starts per third).

Verdict: Partly supported. 543 postseason starts 2020-26, each habit against the pitcher's own season rate, runs per 9 innings per +10 pts: first-pitch strikes -0.33 (CI -0.57 to -0.08), leadoff men reaching +0.59 (CI +0.47 to +0.71), three-ball counts +0.02 (CI -0.28 to +0.32). Aug-Sep regular-season starts: -0.10, +0.54, +0.07.

Don't be afraid to throw fastballs to a fastball-hitting team C04, top of the 1st

What was said. Also in the 1st: don't be afraid to throw fastballs to a fastball-hitting team.

How I tested it. I ranked teams by how much run value they did against fastballs (four-seamers and sinkers) each regular season, and called the top third the fastball-hitting teams. For pitchers with above-median fastballs (by their own fastball run value, 300+ fastballs), I compared run value per 100 pitches on their fastballs vs their secondaries, separately against fastball-hitting teams and everyone else. Pitcher-seasons with 50+ of each pitch type vs each group; bootstrap CI over pitcher-seasons.

Right if. Good fastballs do no worse than the pitcher's own secondaries against fastball-hitting teams. *Data: Statcast 2020-26, regular + post.*

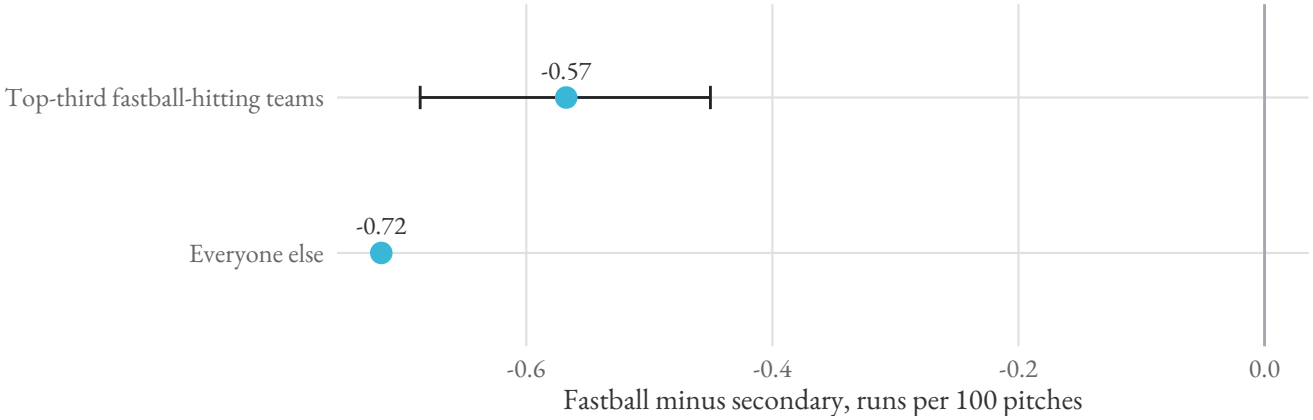


Figure 5: Pitchers with above-median fastballs: fastball run value minus secondary run value, per 100 pitches (hitter's side, so below zero means the fastball did better).

What I found. Good fastballs beat the same pitcher's secondaries against everybody, and they still do against the teams that hit fastballs best. The edge shrinks a little (from about 0.72 to 0.57 runs per 100) but does not come close to flipping. Smoltz's advice holds: a good fastball does not need to hide from a fastball-hitting lineup.

Caveats. Pitchers choose when to throw fastballs, so the comparison is between pitches as they were actually used, not a controlled swap. Team fastball skill is measured over the same season the pitches come from.

Verdict: Supported. 2020-26, pitchers with above-median fastballs (1234 pitcher-seasons): against the top third of fastball-hitting teams their fastballs gave up -0.57 runs per 100 vs their own secondaries (CI -0.69 to -0.45); against everyone else -0.72.

Non-competitive pitches kill pitch count C08, top of the 2nd

What was said. In the 2nd: non-competitive pitches kill a pitch count.

How I tested it. For every start from 2020 to 2026, I measured the share of pitches more than 6 inches off the zone in any direction and the pitches thrown per batter faced. The test compares starts within the same pitcher-season, so it is not just wild pitchers being wild.

Right if. Positive and meaningful. Near-certain by construction: scored on size, not direction. *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

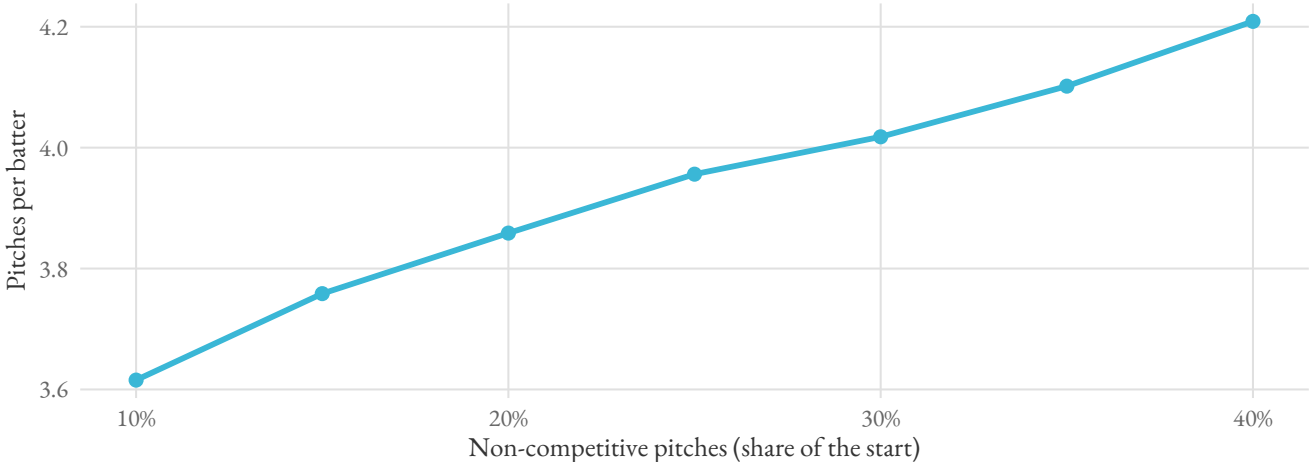


Figure 6: Starts 2020-26: pitches per batter faced by share of non-competitive pitches (bins with 100+ starts).

What I found. True, and nearly by construction: every pitch well off the plate is a pitch that rarely ends an at-bat. Ten more points of waste adds about 0.17 pitches per batter, roughly 0.7 per inning or 4 over a six-inning start.

Caveats. The claim was close to certain going in; the value here is the size, not the direction.

Verdict: Supported. 30,166 starts 2020-26, within pitcher-season: 10 more points of non-competitive pitches (6+ inches off the zone) adds 0.17 pitches per batter (CI 0.16-0.18), about 0.7 pitches per inning.

When a hitter is hot, make sure it's not down the middle C10, top of the 3rd

What was said. In the 3rd: when a hitter is hot, make sure the pitch is not down the middle.

How I tested it. A hitter is hot when his expected wOBA over the previous 14 days (30+ PAs) is in the top tenth of his gaps above his own season line. I took every pitch to that hitter in the regular season 2020-26 and asked whether being hot changes his result on middle-middle pitches more than it changes his result on all other pitches (a difference-in-differences, same hitter-season, same count and pitch type).

Right if. Hot hitters beat their own heart-pitch baseline (CI excludes zero); otherwise middle pitches are equally dangerous to everyone. *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

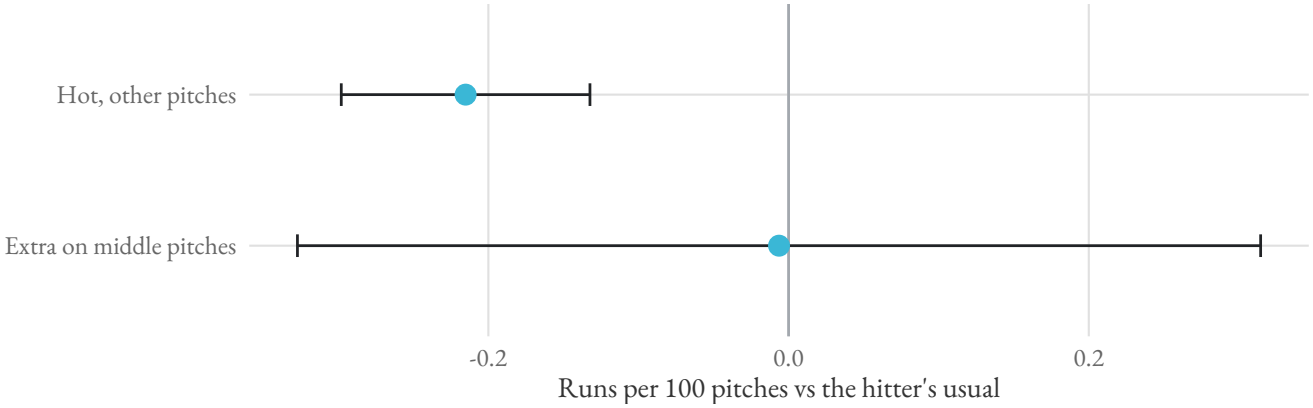


Figure 7: Hot hitters, run value per 100 pitches vs their own usual (hitter's side): on all other pitches, and the extra on middle pitches.

What I found. There is no extra danger on middle pitches. A hot hitter is not more dangerous on a mistake than he always is; a middle pitch is about as bad an idea against him as against anyone. If anything, hot hitters do a little worse than their season line afterward on other pitches, which is ordinary regression to the mean.

Caveats. My first version compared hot hitters with their season baseline, which includes the hot stretch itself and is biased against the claim (it came out negative). The difference-in-differences cancels that. The advice to avoid the middle is still sound; it is just not special to hot hitters.

Verdict: Not supported. 2020-26 regular season, hitters in a hot 14-day stretch (top 10% vs their own season xwOBA): on middle pitches they gain -0.01 runs per 100 more than their hot-stretch change on other pitches (CI -0.33 to +0.31; 58,072 hot middle pitches). Hot or not, a middle pitch is about equally dangerous. (My first version compared against the season baseline, which includes the hot stretch itself and is biased low, so I replaced it.)

Bauers will have the 3-0 green light early C11, top of the 3rd

What was said. Also in the 3rd, about Jake Bauers: he will have the green light on 3-0 early.

How I tested it. I counted Bauers' swings on 3-0 pitches (no intentional balls or bunts) from 2024 to 2026, first in innings 1-3 (the 'early' in the claim) and then overall, against the league's 3-0 swing rate over the same seasons, and checked his 3-0 count in Game 3 from the StatsAPI feed. Binomial confidence intervals; fewer than 15 early pitches would be too few to call.

Right if. Bauers swings at 3-0 clearly more than the league (binomial CI above the league rate). Fewer than 15 3-0 pitches = Inconclusive. *Data: Statcast 2024-26.*

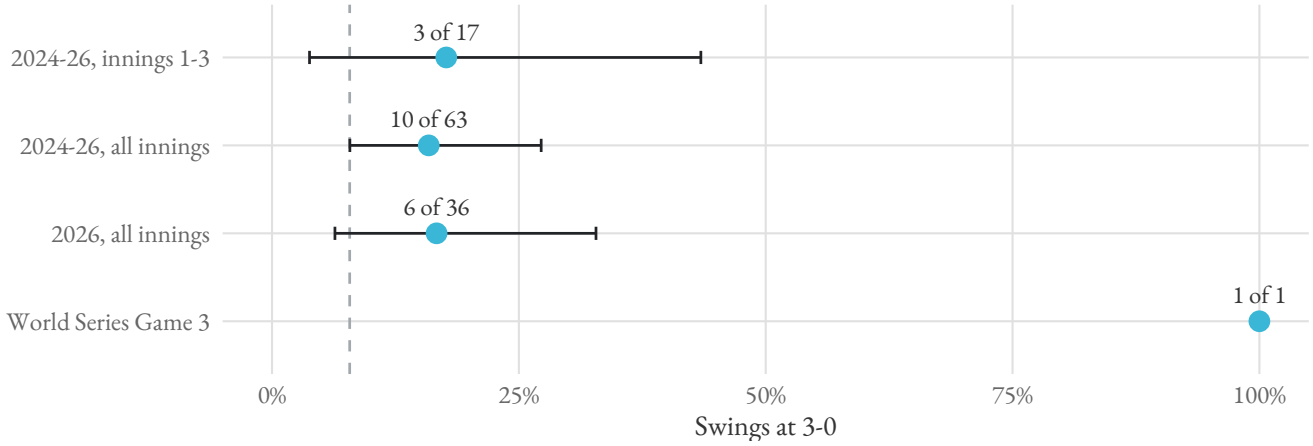


Figure 8: Jake Bauers' 3-0 swing rate with 95% intervals; dashed line = league 3-0 swing rate, 2024-26.

What I found. Smoltz knows his man. Bauers swings at 3-0 about twice as often as the league, and in Game 3 he did exactly what Smoltz said: 3-0 in the 3rd, and he swung. What the data cannot do is confirm the early part at the bar I set, because 17 early-inning 3-0 pitches in three seasons is too few to separate him from the league.

Caveats. One hitter, small counts. The verdict is Not supported only in the narrow sense that the early-inning rate is not clearly above the league; the broader read of Bauers is right.

Verdict: Not supported. Jake Bauers swung at 3 of 17 3-0 pitches in innings 1-3 over 2024-26 (18%) and 10 of 63 in all innings (16%), vs a league 3-0 swing rate of 7.9%. He does swing at 3-0 about 2.0 times as often as the league overall (CI 8%-27%), so the read on Bauers is reasonable; the early-inning sample is too small to confirm the 'early' part. In Game 3 itself he got 1 3-0 count (inning 3) and swung at 1.

Hitters get a greener 3-0 light in the playoffs **T05, top of the 3rd, my question**

What was said. My own follow-up to the Bauers line: does the whole league get a greener 3-0 light in October?

How I tested it. For every hitter-season from 2020 to 2026 with 3-0 pitches in both the regular season (5+) and the postseason, I took the change in 3-0 swing rate, postseason minus regular season, and averaged it weighted by postseason 3-0 pitches. Bootstrap CI over hitter-seasons.

Right if. Mean within-player change above zero (CI excludes zero). *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

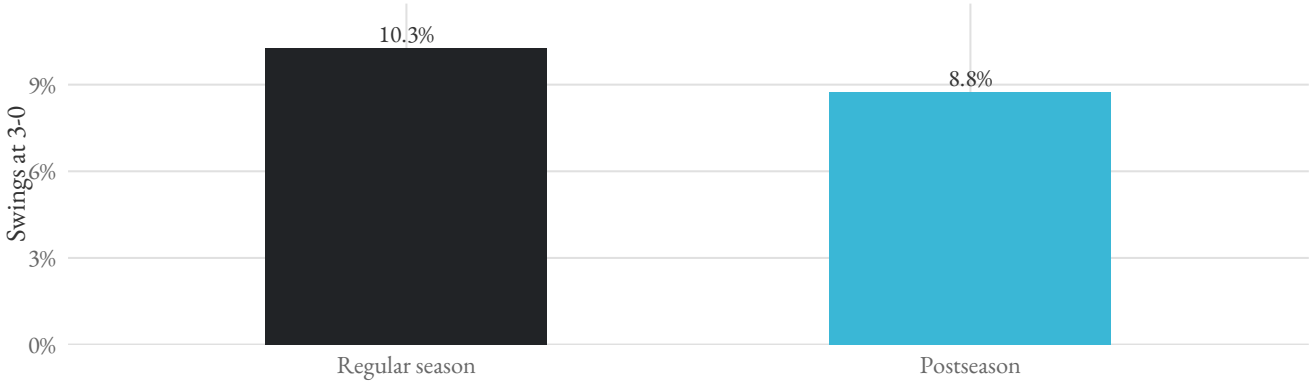


Figure 9: Same hitters, 3-0 swing rate in the regular season vs the postseason, 2020-26.

What I found. No. The same hitters swing at 3-0 slightly less in October, not more. Bauers is a 3-0 swinger in every month; October does not turn other hitters into one.

Caveats. About 940 postseason 3-0 pitches in total, so the estimate is loose (CI about -3.5 to +0.5 points).

Verdict: Not supported. 2020-26, 446 hitter-seasons with a 3-0 pitch in both: the same hitters swung at 3-0 8.8% in October vs 10.3% in their regular season (-1.5 pts, CI -3.5 pts to +0.4 pts).

Lefty: sinker in to a righty sets up the changeup away C13, bottom of the 3rd

What was said. In the bottom of the 3rd, on a lefty pitching to a righty: the sinker in sets up the changeup away.

How I tested it. I took every changeup away (outer third and beyond) from a left-hander to a right-handed hitter, 2020 to 2026, that was not the first pitch of the at-bat, and compared the ones thrown right after a sinker in (inner third and beyond) with all the others. Whiffs per swing and run value, with pitcher-season and count held fixed.

Right if. The setup lifts whiff % or lowers run value (CI excludes zero). *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

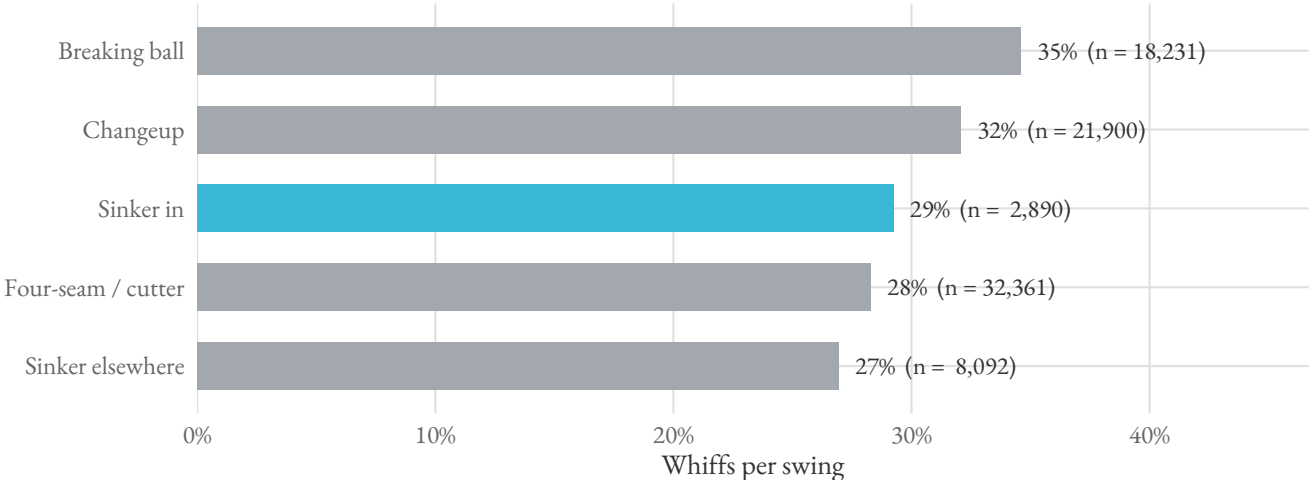


Figure 10: Lefties' changeups away to righties: whiffs per swing by the pitch before it.

What I found. The setup does not show up. Changeups away after a sinker in get about the same whiffs and the same run value as changeups away after anything else, once the pitcher and count are held equal. The sequence is a good story; the numbers say the changeup does the work on its own.

Caveats. Pitchers pick their sequences on purpose, and only about 2,900 changeups followed a sinker in. A small setup effect (a point or two of whiffs) cannot be ruled out.

Verdict: Not supported. 2020-26, lefties' changeups away to righties (83,474, 2,890 right after a sinker in): after the sinker-in setup, whiffs per swing -0.3 pts (CI -2.5 pts to +2.0 pts) and run value -0.6 runs per 100 for the hitter (CI -1.4 to +0.2), same pitcher and count.

Elite stuff gets results even when the ball goes where it wants C14, bottom of the 3rd

What was said. Also in the 3rd: some pitchers can throw it wherever they want and still get results, unlike pitchers who live on command.

How I tested it. I scored every four-seamer pitcher-season (300+ four-seamers) on 'stuff': velocity plus induced vertical break, standardized within the season. Then I took only the four-seamers left over the heart of the plate, the clearest mistakes, and compared what hitters did against each tenth of stuff.

Right if. Top-tier stuff gives up clearly less on mislocated pitches than average stuff. *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

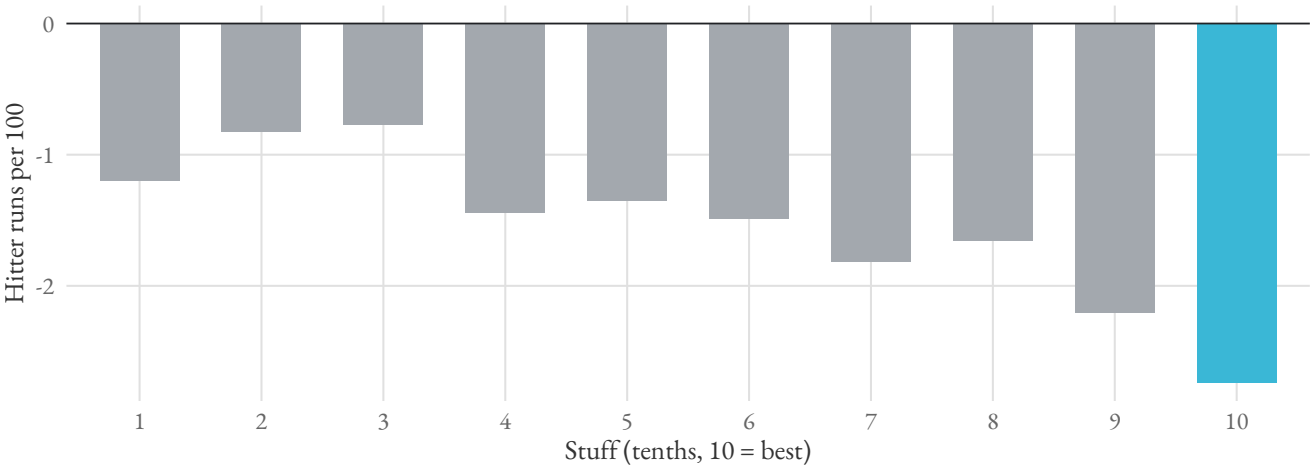


Figure 11: Four-seamers over the heart of the plate, 2020-26: hitters' run value per 100 by the pitcher's stuff (tenths, 10 = best).

What I found. Supported. A middle-middle four-seamer from top-tenth stuff costs the pitcher noticeably less than the same mistake from average stuff, and it draws more whiffs. Elite stuff does buy a margin for error.

Caveats. Stuff here is only velocity and ride on four-seamers; it ignores extension, approach angle and the rest of the arsenal. 'Heart of the plate' is a location bin, not the pitcher's intended target.

Verdict: Supported. 2020-26 four-seamers down the middle: hitters gained -2.7 runs per 100 off top-10% stuff (velo + ride) vs -1.4 off middle-tier stuff; the gap at equal count is -1.4 per 100 (CI -1.8 to -0.9). Whiffs per swing on those pitches: 19.1% vs 15.1%.

The middle/opposite-field approach is the anti-launch-angle approach; the launch-angle approach leads to too much whiff C21, top of the 6th

What was said. In the 6th: the middle/opposite-field approach is the anti-launch-angle approach, and the launch-angle approach leads to too much whiff.

How I tested it. For hitter-seasons with 200+ balls in play, 2020 to 2026, I measured the share of balls in play to the middle or opposite field (spray angle at least 15 degrees from the pull line) and compared it with whiffs per swing, launch angle and barrel rate. Part 7 takes the mechanics apart with bat tracking.

Right if. Middle/oppo-heavy hitters whiff LESS than pull/launch-angle hitters (CI excludes zero). I corrected the direction on 2026-10-26 after the first run: in my note, 'it leads to too much whiff' refers to the launch-angle approach. *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

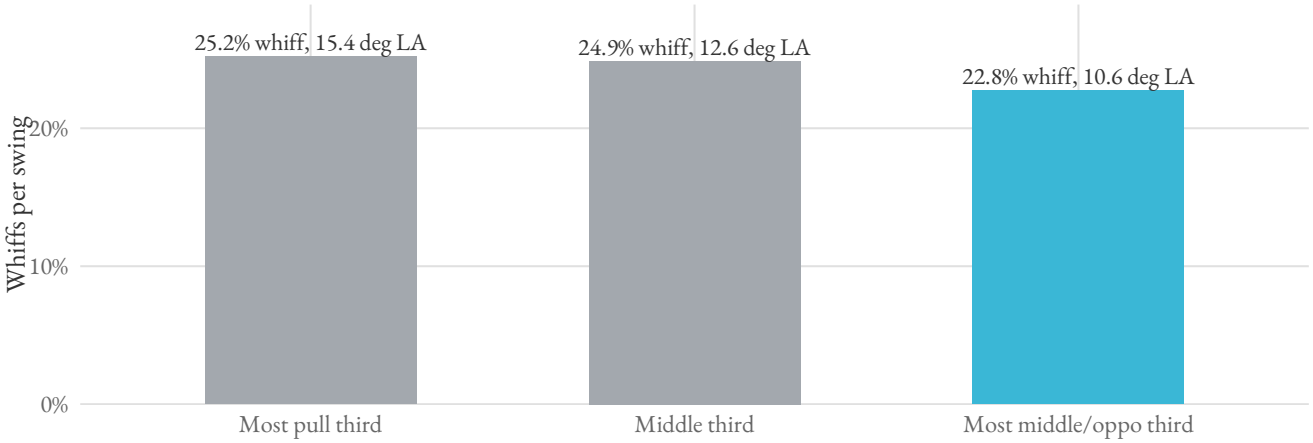


Figure 12: Hitter-seasons 2020-26 in thirds of pull share: whiffs per swing and average launch angle.

What I found. Right on both halves. Middle/oppo hitters hit the ball at lower launch angles (it really is the anti-launch-angle approach) and whiff less, about 2 points per 10 points of middle/oppo share.

Caveats. My first run tested the opposite direction, because I misread my own note: it is the launch-angle approach that 'leads to too much whiff'. Part 7 shows the whiff gap is the flatter swing, not the direction itself.

Verdict: Supported. 2020-26, 1,660 hitter-seasons (200+ balls in play): 10 more points of middle/opposite-field contact goes with -2.1 pts whiffs per swing (CI -3.0 pts to -1.2 pts). The most middle/oppo third whiffed 22.8% and averaged a 10.6-degree launch angle; the most pull-heavy third whiffed 25.2% at 15.4 degrees. Part 7 takes the mechanics apart.

Three-two count: ball-four-or-base-hit mentality C22, top of the 6th

What was said. In the 6th, on a full count: the hitter's mentality is ball four or a base hit.

How I tested it. For hitter-seasons with 30+ full-count PAs and 15+ full-count pitches out of the zone, 2020 to 2026, I measured how often the hitter chased at 3-2 and his wOBA in PAs that reached 3-2, against his overall wOBA (so better hitters do not drive the result).

Right if. Low-chase 3-2 hitters produce more on 3-2. *Data: Statcast 2020-26.*

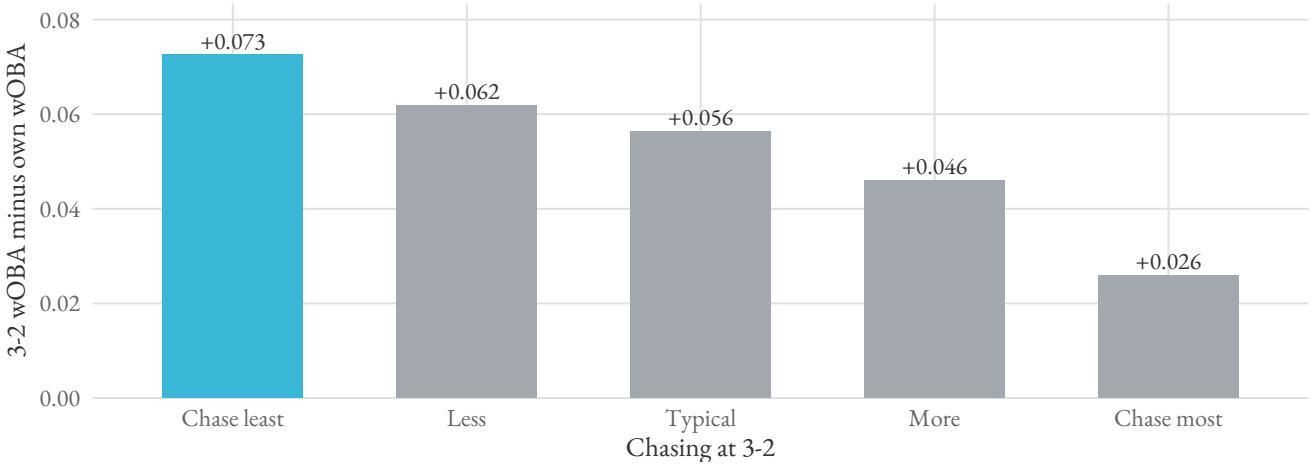


Figure 13: Full-count wOBA above each hitter's own overall wOBA, by how often he chases at 3-2 (fifths of hitter-seasons).

What I found. Supported. Hitters who take the ball-four route at 3-2 get more out of full counts relative to their own level, about .016 wOBA per 10 fewer points of chasing. The full count is where discipline pays the most.

Caveats. Disciplined hitters may differ in other ways that help at 3-2 (pitch recognition, two-strike contact).

Verdict: Supported. 2020-26, 2,090 hitter-seasons with 30+ full-count PAs: 10 more points of chasing at 3-2 changes 3-2 wOBA by -0.016 at equal overall wOBA (CI -0.018 to -0.014).

The zone is more generous away than in, by batter hand (said early, noted in B6) C24, bottom of the 6th

What was said. Early in the game (noted in the 6th): the zone is more generous away than in, depending on the hitter's side.

How I tested it. I took every called pitch (balls and called strikes) in the vertical middle of the zone, 2025 and 2026 regular seasons, and compared called-strike rates on the away side and the inside at the same horizontal distance from the middle of the plate, by batter hand. 2026 had the ABS challenge system; 2025 did not.

Right if. Outer-edge called-strike rate exceeds inner at the same distance. *Data: Statcast 2026 (2025 for a pre-ABS check).*

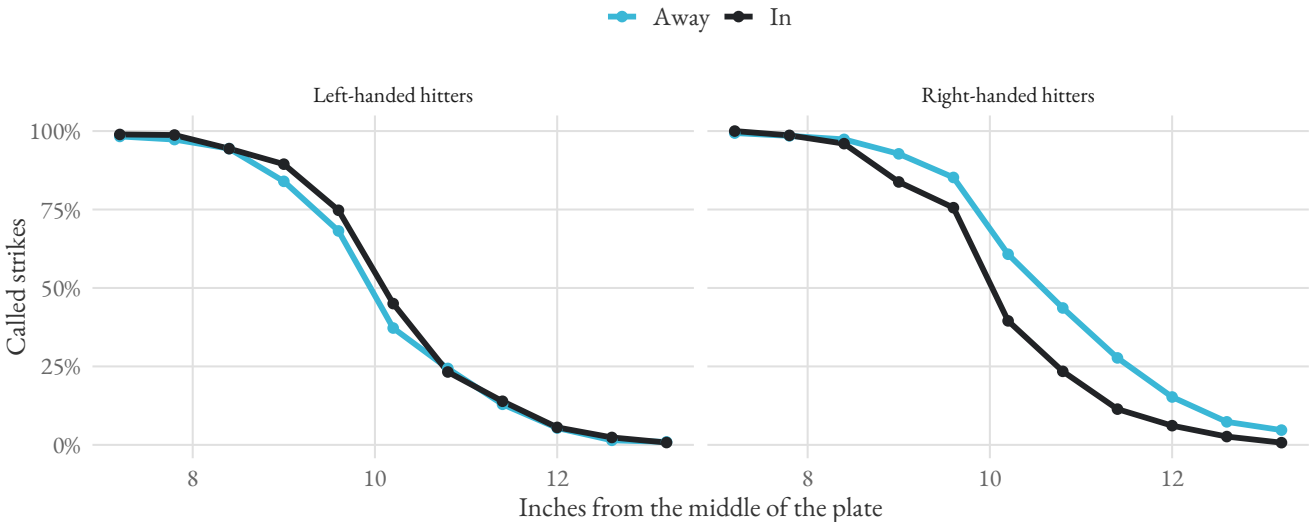


Figure 14: Called-strike rate by distance from the middle of the plate, away vs in, 2026 regular season.

What I found. Supported overall, but it is a right-handed-hitter story. Against righties, the away edge gets about 9 points more called strikes than the inside edge at the same distance; against lefties it is slightly the other way. The gap was bigger in 2025, before challenges, so ABS has trimmed it but not erased it.

Caveats. My reading of my note ('outer strikes, inner call% way higher') is that the outer edge is the generous one. The pitch tracker's plate_x is the ball's center at the front of the plate, not where the umpire saw it.

Verdict: Supported. 2026 called pitches at the same distance from the middle of the plate: +3.4 pts more called strikes away than in (log-odds +0.33, CI +0.26 to +0.40); vs RHB +9.2 pts, vs LHB -2.3 pts. 2025 (before ABS challenges): +7.5 pts.

Takeaway. The pitching claims hold up: first-pitch strikes and leadoff outs, fastballs against fastball hitters, stuff that survives a mistake, a wider zone away, and full-count discipline. So does his read that middle/oppo hitters whiff less. The misses are the hot-hitter warning and one specific sequence. (Smoltz: 7 of 10 supported or partly supported.)

Part 2

Innings and bases

Claims about what happens inside an inning: leadoff men, walks, jams, two-out runs, runners and pickoffs.

The starter sets the temperature for the team in the first inning C02, top of the 1st

What was said. In the top of the 1st: the starter sets the temperature for the whole team.

How I tested it. Every scoreless top of the 1st leaves the game 0-0, so the scoreboard cannot tell a 1-2-3 inning from a scoreless inning with runners on. That makes a clean test of 'temperature': for 48,199 games from 1998 to 2025, I compared home win % (and home runs in the bottom of the 1st) after a 1-2-3 top of the 1st vs a scoreless one with traffic, at equal team strength (both teams' season win %).

Right if. 1-2-3 first lifts home win % by 2+ points (CI above zero); CI above zero but under 2 = Partly. Bottom-1st runs is the cleaner test of the team part (the win % edge can just be the starter being sharp that day). *Data: Retrosheet 1998-2025, all games.*

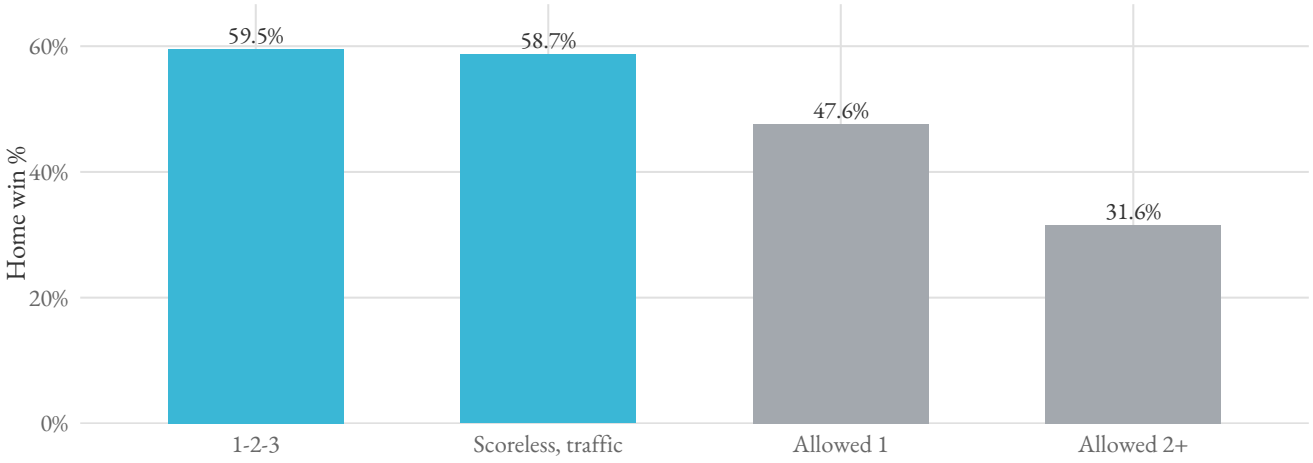


Figure 15: Home win % by how the home starter's top of the 1st went, 1998-2025.

What I found. The scoreboard is what matters. Runs in the 1st matter a great deal, but between the two scoreless versions the gap is under half a point and not distinguishable from zero, and the home offense scores no more in the bottom of the 1st after a 1-2-3 inning. There is no temperature to set beyond the runs.

Caveats. A 1-2-3 inning partly signals a sharp starter, which should help later innings; the win % comparison would credit that to 'temperature' and still finds almost nothing.

Verdict: Not supported. 1998-2025, 48,199 scoreless top 1sts: after a 1-2-3 first the home team won 59.5% of the time, +0.4 pts vs a scoreless first with traffic at equal team strength (CI -0.4 pts to +1.3 pts). The offense part is -0.007 runs in the bottom 1st (CI -0.027 to +0.013).

A slow runner in front of a fast runner cancels the speed C06, bottom of the 1st

What was said. In the bottom of the 1st: a slow runner in front of a fast runner cancels the speed.

How I tested it. On singles and doubles with a runner on first, 2022 to 2025, I tracked whether that trailing runner took the extra base (first to third, or scored, on a single; scored on a double), by his sprint-speed third and by who was ahead of him: nobody on second, or a slow, middling or fast lead runner. The test is how much of the fast runner's edge over a slow one survives behind a slow lead runner. Steal attempts were dropped, because with second occupied a lone steal is not possible.

Right if. The fast runner's edge shrinks by half or more behind a slow lead runner. *Data: Retrosheet 2022-25 + Savant sprint speed.*

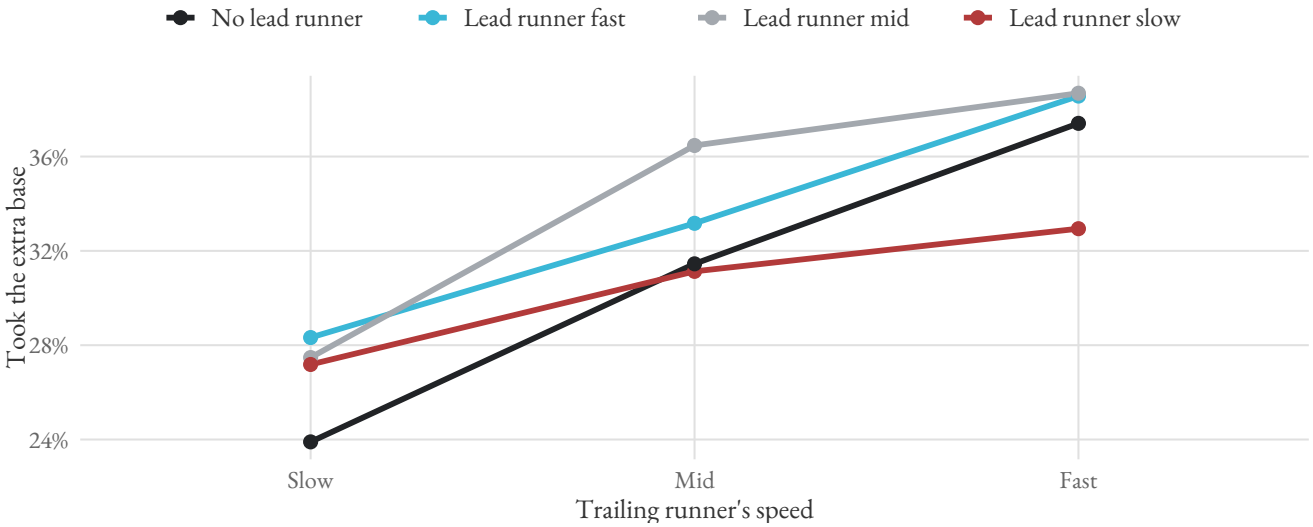


Figure 16: Singles with a runner on first, 2022-25: share of trailing runners who took the extra base, by their speed and the lead runner.

What I found. Partly right. With nobody on second, a fast runner goes first to third about 13.5 points more often than a slow one. Behind a slow runner on second, that edge falls to about 6 points: the slow runner does take away more than half of it. The estimate is loose (43% of the edge survives, CI 13-75%), so I can say it blunts the speed, not that it cancels it.

Caveats. I sharpened this rule before running it (steals dropped). Speed thirds come from season sprint speed, and runners' read on the ball and third-base coaching are not measured.

Verdict: Partly supported. 2022-25 singles with a man on first: a fast trailing runner goes first-to-third +13.5 pts more often than a slow one with no one on second, and +5.8 pts more often behind a slow runner on second, so 43% of the speed edge survives (95% CI 13-75%; claim needs 50% or less).

Pickoff throws split the pitcher's attention and help the hitter C07, bottom of the 1st

What was said. Also in the 1st: pickoff throws split the pitcher's attention, and that helps the hitter.

How I tested it. With a runner on first and second base open, 2023 to 2025 (the pitch-timer era), I compared hitters' wOBA in PAs where the pitcher threw over at least once vs not, holding runner speed, hitter and pitcher quality, outs, base state and the length of the PA equal. Throws come from Retrosheet pitch strings.

Right if. wOBA is higher after throws over (CI excludes zero). *Data: Retrosheet 2023-25 pitch strings.*

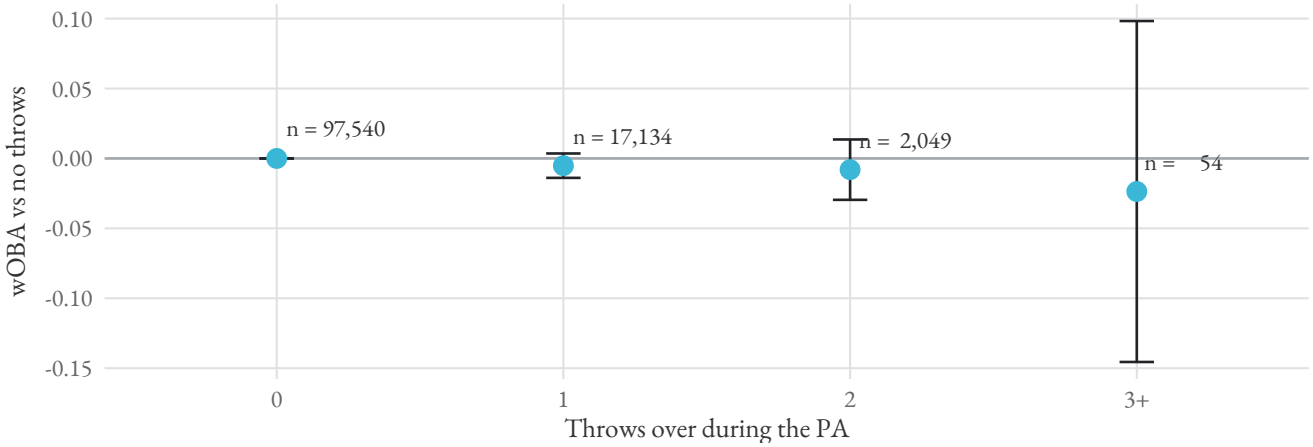


Figure 17: Hitters' wOBA after 1, 2 or 3+ throws over vs none, adjusted (95% intervals), runner on first and second open, 2023-25.

What I found. No help for the hitter. Raw wOBA is actually lower after throws over (.313 vs .332), mostly because pitchers throw over to fast runners and in tighter spots. Adjusted, the difference is about zero at every number of throws.

Caveats. Pitchers decide when to throw over, so this cannot fully separate the throw from the situation that prompted it.

Verdict: Not supported. 2023-25, runner on first and second base open (116,777 PAs): hitters' wOBA -0.006 when the pitcher threw over at least once vs not, after runner speed, hitter and pitcher quality, outs and PA length (CI -0.014 to +0.003). Raw: 0.313 vs 0.332.

Get the leadoff hitter and the offense goes down C09, top of the 2nd

What was said. In the 2nd: get the leadoff hitter and the offense goes down; pitch him like the last out of the 9th.

How I tested it. Every half-inning from 2022 to 2025 that started with the bases empty and nobody out (innings 1-8 and the top of the 9th, so walk-offs and automatic runners never enter): did the inning score, by whether the leadoff man reached, regular season vs postseason.

Right if. Leadoff-on innings score clearly more often (known result; also check whether October is different). *Data: Retrosheet 2022-25.*

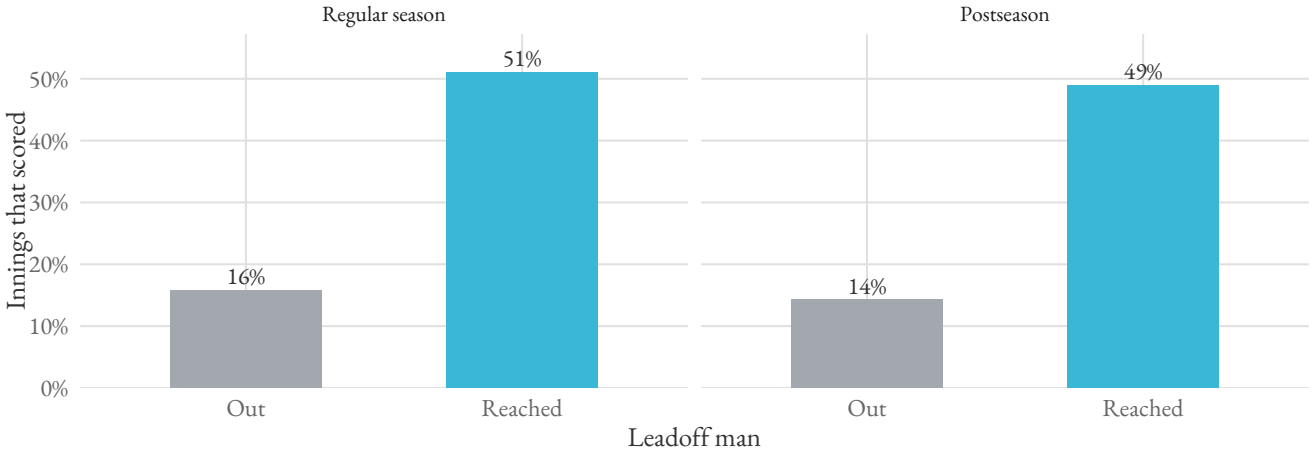


Figure 18: Share of innings that scored, by whether the leadoff man reached, 2022-25.

What I found. One of the oldest truths in the game, and it holds: an inning scores about half the time when the leadoff man reaches and about one time in six when he is out. October looks the same.

Caveats. A known result; included because it was said.

Verdict: Supported. 2022-25 regular season: innings scored 51.1% of the time after the leadoff man reached vs 15.8% after he was out (+35.3 pts, CI +34.8 pts to +35.7 pts); postseason 49.0% vs 14.2% (+34.7 pts). October looks the same.

Walks will haunt you (1B-BB-1B vs three singles) C12, top of the 3rd

What was said. In the 3rd, after a single, a walk and a single: walks will haunt you.

How I tested it. I found every run of three straight plate appearances in the same half-inning, starting with the bases empty and nothing in between (no steals or wild pitches), that went single-single-single, single-walk-single, walk-single-single or single-single-walk, and averaged the runs scored from the first of them to the end of the inning (weighting out states like the three-singles group). 2022-25 is the main window; 1998-2025 is the check.

Right if. A walk-containing sequence yields 75%+ of the three-singles runs = Supported; 50-75% = Partly; under 50% = Not supported. *Data: Retrosheet 2022-25.*

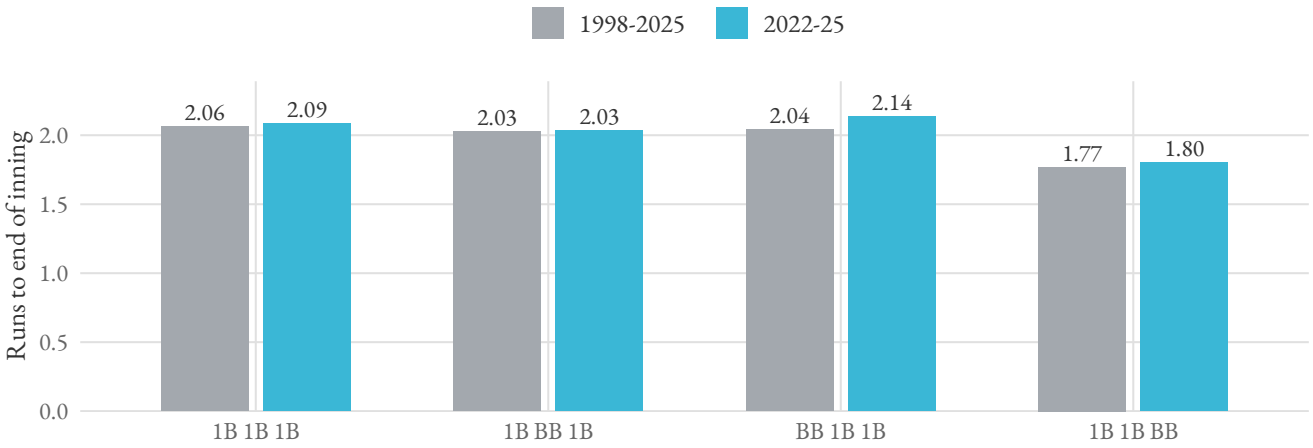


Figure 19: Runs from the start of the sequence to the end of the inning, starting with the bases empty.

What I found. Supported. A walk in the middle of a three-batter rally costs almost nothing compared with a single (98% of the runs), and a leadoff walk is just as good. The exception is the one my note guessed: when the walk comes last, it cannot drive in a run, and the sequence is worth about 86% as much.

Caveats. I set the 75% / 50% tiers before running. Real sequences carry their own context (who was hitting, how hard the singles were).

Verdict: Supported. From empty bases, 2022-25: 1B-BB-1B is worth 2.03 runs to the end of the inning vs 2.09 for three singles (98%, 95% CI 90-105%); BB-1B-1B 102%, 1B-1B-BB 86%. A walk costs the most when it is the last of the three, because it cannot drive a run in.

Escaping a mid-inning jam while trailing swings the game C17, top of the 5th

What was said. In the 5th: getting out of a mid-inning jam while you are down changes the game.

How I tested it. For every half-inning in the 4th to 6th from 1998 to 2025 where the fielding team trailed by 1 to 3 and allowed no runs, I compared teams that stranded a jam (runner in scoring position with fewer than two outs) with teams that never faced one. Both end the half-inning at the same score, so any gap in final win % is momentum. Team strength and the exact inning, half and deficit are held equal.

Right if. Escaped-jam teams beat the same-score win expectancy by 2+ points (CI excludes zero). *Data: Retrosheet 1998-2025.*

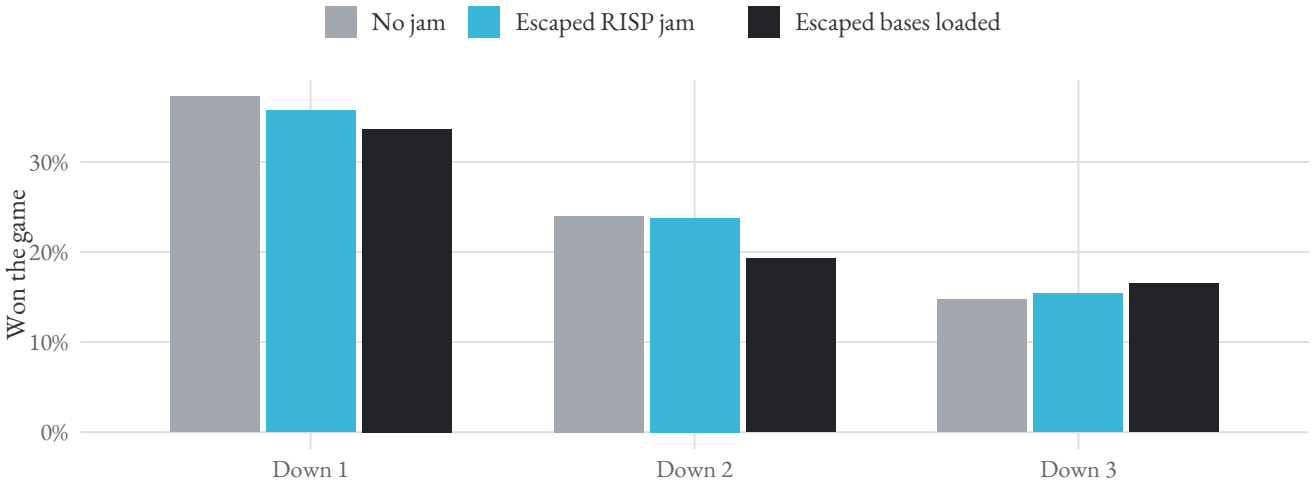


Figure 20: Final win % of the trailing fielding team after a scoreless half-inning, by deficit and whether it escaped a jam, 1998-2025.

What I found. Escaping a jam does not change who wins. Teams that strand a jam win at the same rate as teams that had a quiet inning at the same score, within a point either way, and bases-loaded escapes are no different.

Caveats. A jam also says the other offense is hitting that day, which would work against the escaping team; even so there is no sign of a lift.

Verdict: Not supported. 1998-2025, trailing by 1-3 in innings 4-6: teams that stranded a less-than-two-out RISP jam won -0.4 pts vs teams with the same score and no jam (CI -1.2 pts to +0.3 pts, 14,288 escapes). Bases-loaded escapes: -1.8 pts.

Two-out baserunners kill in the postseason C18, top of the 5th

What was said. Also in the 5th: two-out baserunners kill in the postseason.

How I tested it. For 2022 to 2025, I tracked every batter who reached base and whether he came around to score that inning, by outs when he reached, postseason vs regular season. I also compared the share of all runs that scored with two outs.

Right if. Two-out conversion is higher in the postseason than in the regular season. *Data: Retrosheet 2022-25.*

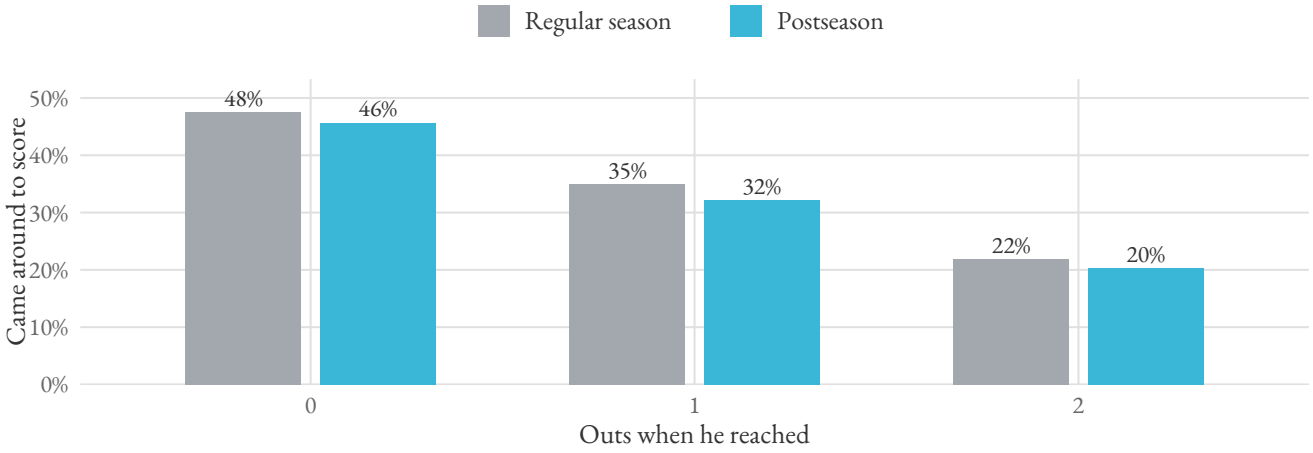


Figure 21: Share of batters who reached base and later scored, by outs, 2022-25.

What I found. Two-out runners do not do more damage in October. A two-out baserunner scored a little less often in the postseason than in the regular season, and two-out runs were a smaller share of postseason runs. Two-out rallies matter in any month; October does not make them special.

Caveats. The claim could be read loosely ('two-out runs hurt'), which is true and empty. I tested the playoff-specific version because that is what was said.

Verdict: Not supported. 2022-25: a two-out baserunner scored 20.3% of the time in the postseason vs 21.9% in the regular season (-1.6 pts, CI -3.9 pts to +0.7 pts). Two-out runs were 34.9% of postseason runs vs 38.2% in the regular season.

Takeaway. The textbook claims (leadoff men, walks) are right; the momentum claims (a clean first, an escaped jam) and the October-specific one (two-out runners) find nothing. A slow lead runner does blunt a fast trailer, by about half. (Smoltz: 3 of 7 supported or partly supported.)

Part 3

Games and series

Claims about who wins games and series: baserunning, bullpens, streaks, and what a loss does to the next game.

Baserunners, steals and two-out hits win postseason games C01, pre-game

What was said. Before the first pitch: baserunners win games, with steals and two-out hits turning runners into runs and runs into wins, and that showed up in two games already.

How I tested it. For every team-game in 2022-25, I modeled winning on the team's baserunners, stolen bases and two-out hits, with the opponent's baserunners held equal, separately for the regular season and the postseason, and compared the two. Then the same model on all postseasons from 1998 to 2025 for more power.

Right if. Steals and two-out hits predict winning at least as strongly in the postseason as in the regular season, beyond baserunners alone. *Data: Retrosheet 2022-25 postseason (2026 not included: Statcast files carry no steal events); regular season same years.*

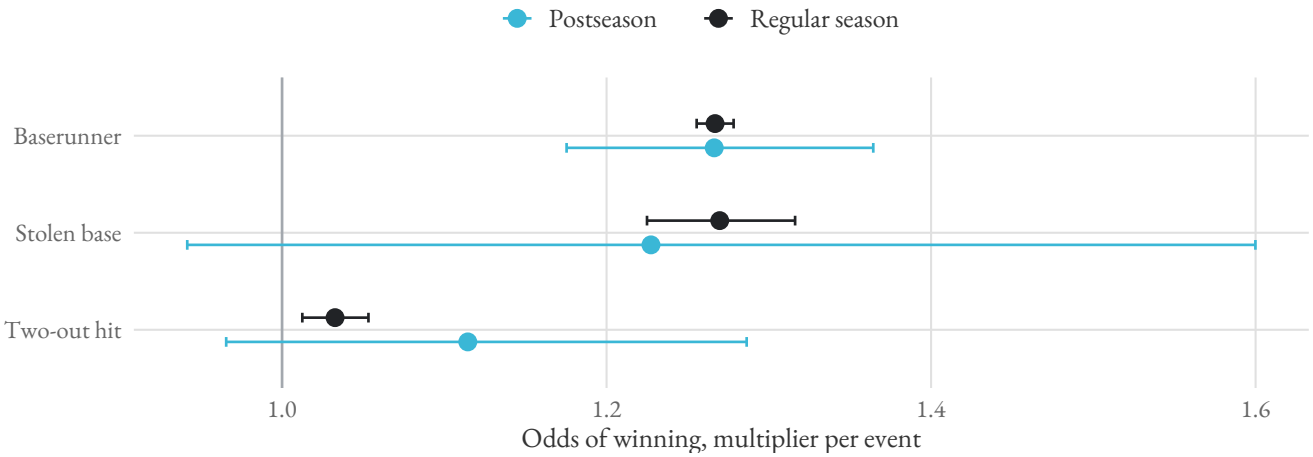


Figure 22: Odds multiplier for winning per steal, per two-out hit and per baserunner, 2022-25, with 95% intervals.

What I found. Steals and two-out hits do help win games, and in October about as much as in the regular season. Across all postseasons since 1998, a steal multiplies the odds of winning by about 1.28 and a two-out hit by about 1.10. Four Octobers of the 12-team format are just too few games to separate either one from zero on their own.

Caveats. I added the Inconclusive tier for this case: October matches the regular season, but the 2022-25 window alone cannot confirm it. Statcast has no steal events, so 2026 is not in the test.

Verdict: Inconclusive. 2022-25, with both teams' baserunners held equal: each steal multiplies the odds of winning by 1.23x in the postseason (CI 0.94x-1.60x) vs 1.27x in the regular season; each two-out hit by 1.11x in the postseason (CI 0.97x-1.29x) vs 1.03x. Baserunners themselves: 1.27x per runner in October. All postseasons 1998-2025: steals 1.28x (CI 1.13x-1.45x), two-out hits 1.10x (CI 1.04x-1.17x).

You have to beat the bullpens in the playoffs, especially good ones C16, top of the 5th

What was said. In the 5th: you have to beat the bullpens in the playoffs, especially the good ones.

How I tested it. For every multi-game postseason series from 1998 to 2025 (220), I compared the two teams' regular-season bullpen runs allowed per nine (relievers only) and asked whether a better pen predicts winning the series once overall run differential is held equal. A game-level version adds home field.

Right if. Bullpen edge predicts series wins beyond run differential. *Data: Retrosheet 1998-2025, 2022+ split out.*

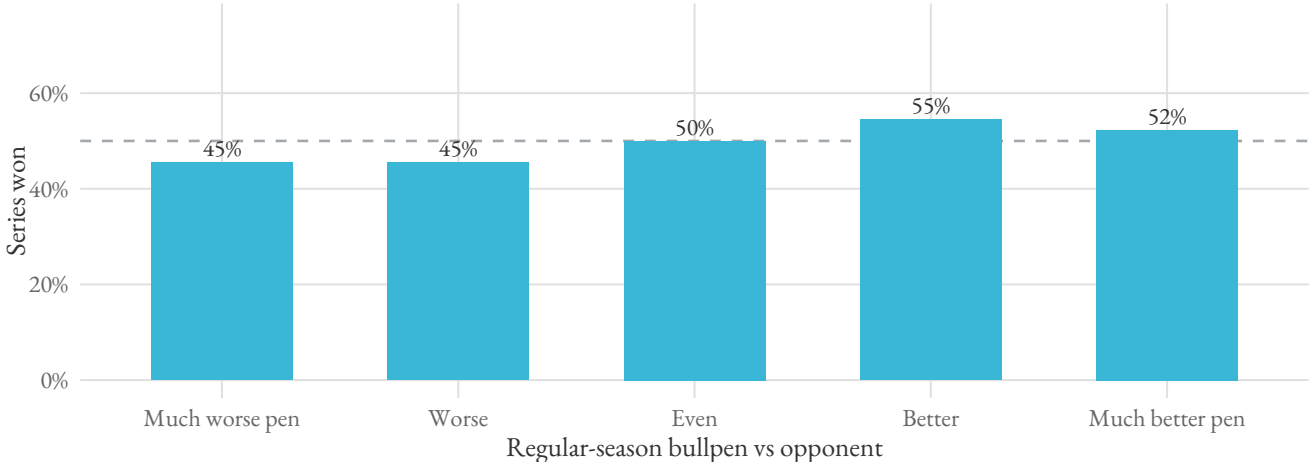


Figure 23: Series won by bullpen edge over the opponent (fifths of series), 1998-2025.

What I found. A better bullpen does not predict a series win once team quality is known. Teams with much better pens did win a little more often (52% vs 45% for much worse pens), but those teams were better overall; at equal run differential the pen adds nothing. In the 2022-25 format the team with the better pen won fewer than half of its series.

Caveats. Regular-season bullpen numbers include relievers who are not used in October, and managers lean harder on their best arms in the playoffs. A sharper test would use the top three or four relievers only.

Verdict: Not supported. 1998-2025, 220 multi-game series: a bullpen 1 run per 9 better in the regular season changes the log-odds of winning the series by -0.03 at equal run differential (CI -0.41 to +0.36); per game -0.5 pts (CI -5.4 pts to +4.3 pts). 2022-25: the team with the better pen won 20 of 44 series (45.5%).

A big loss without hitting carries over to the next game C19, bottom of the 5th

What was said. In the bottom of the 5th: a big loss without hitting carries over into the next game.

How I tested it. For every team-game from 1998 to 2025, I compared next-game runs (and win %) with what the team's offense, the next opponent's run prevention and home field predict. The test group is losses by 5+ runs on 4 or fewer hits; the chart shows the gap after every final margin.

Right if. Next-game runs fall below expected (CI excludes zero). *Data: Retrosheet 1998-2025, regular + post.*

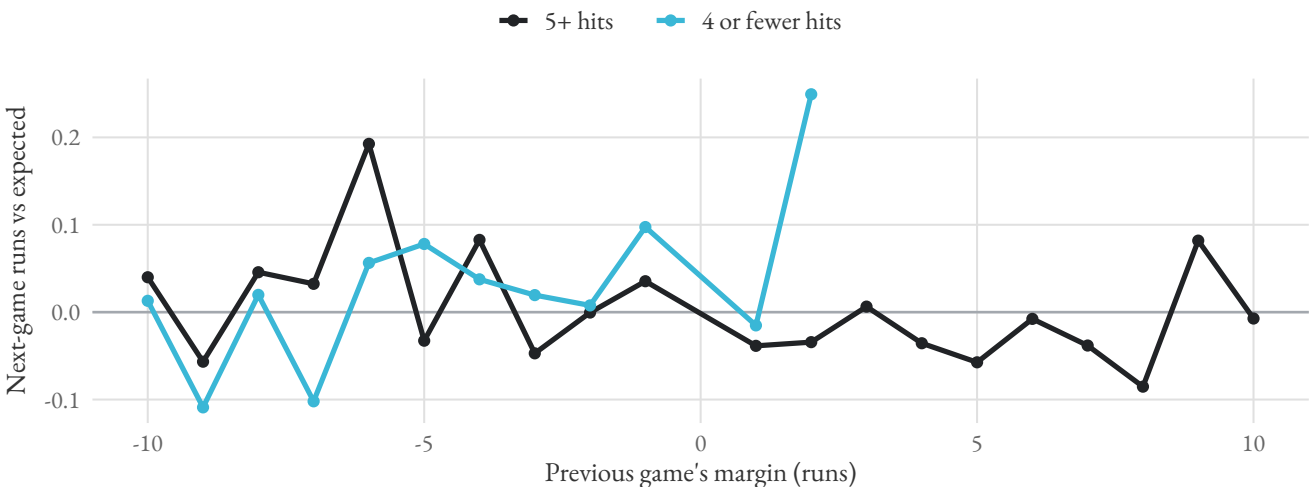


Figure 24: Next-game runs vs expected, by the previous game's margin (losses on the left), 1998-2025.

What I found. Nothing carries over. After a big loss on few hits, teams score what their usual offense predicts the next day, and win at their usual rate. The lines sit on zero across every margin.

Caveats. Expected runs do not include the specific opposing starter, which would sharpen the test but would not create an effect where the averages show none.

Verdict: Not supported. 1998-2025, 3,669 losses by 5+ on 4 or fewer hits: next game the team scored +0.01 runs vs expected for its offense, the opponent's run prevention and home field (CI -0.09 to +0.11); win %: +1.1 pts (CI -0.5 pts to +2.6 pts).

Positive regression on LOB in a seven-game series C20, top of the 6th

What was said. In the 6th: positive regression on LOB in a seven-game series.

How I tested it. Within every postseason series from 1998 to 2025, I measured how many runners each team stranded so far beyond what its regular-season strand rate would leave from the baserunners it had, then compared its runs in the next game with expectation (team offense, opponent run prevention, centered on the postseason average).

Right if. High-LOB teams score MORE than expected later (CI above zero) = Supported. Later runs back at expectation (CI spans zero) after early high-LOB games that ran below it = Partly supported (a return to normal, no bounce). Later runs still below expectation = Contradicted. *Data: Retrosheet 1998-2025 postseason.*

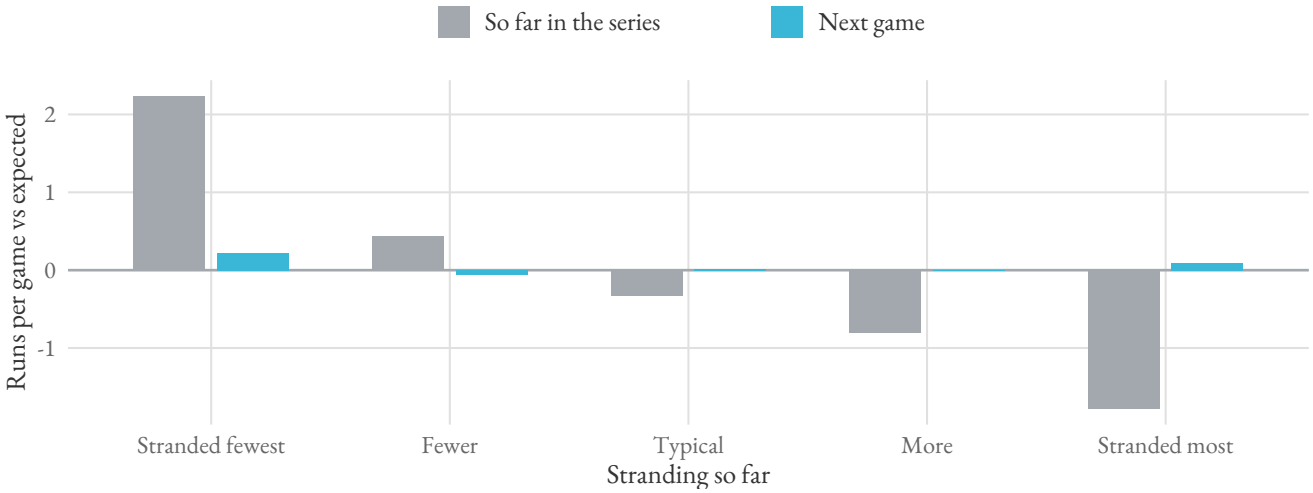


Figure 25: Runs per game vs expectation so far in the series and in the next game, by how much the team had been stranding (fifths).

What I found. Partly right. Teams that had been stranding the most runners were scoring below expectation, and in the next game they scored right at it: their run scoring regressed to normal. There is no bounce above normal, so 'positive regression' is right in the statistician's sense and wrong if it means a rebound.

Caveats. My first version used raw LOB, which mostly counts baserunners: its top fifth was scoring above average. Stranding is now measured against each team's usual rate. I wrote the return-to-normal tier into the rule before running the final version.

Verdict: Partly supported. 1998-2025 postseason series (1,524 team-games after game 1): each extra runner stranded per game so far (beyond the team's usual strand rate for its baserunners) changes next-game runs vs expected by -0.03 (CI -0.12 to +0.06). Teams in the top third for stranding ran -1.43 runs per game vs expectation so far, then +0.04 in the next game (CI -0.22 to +0.30), both against the average postseason team: back to normal, not a bounce above it.

Streaky teams don't succeed in the playoffs; you have to be steady C23, top of the 6th

What was said. Also in the 6th: streaky teams do not succeed in the playoffs; you have to be steady.

How I tested it. For every playoff team from 1998 to 2025, I measured regular-season streakiness two ways (a runs test on the win-loss sequence and the spread of its rolling 15-game win %) and asked whether the streakier team in a series wins less often at equal run differential.

Right if. Streakier teams win fewer series (CI excludes zero). *Data: Retrosheet 1998-2025.*

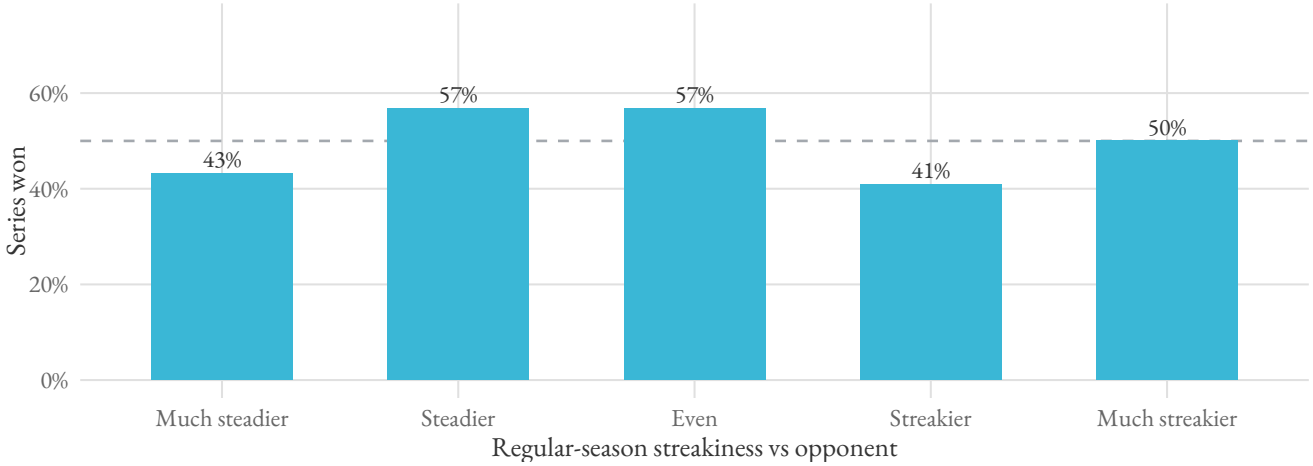


Figure 26: Series won by streakiness relative to the opponent (fifths of series), 1998-2025.

What I found. Steadiness does not predict October success. Streakier teams won their series about as often as steadier ones (if anything slightly more), and both measures agree.

Caveats. Most win-loss streakiness is noise; a team whose streaks came from injuries or roster changes might be a real exception, and that is not separated here.

Verdict: Not supported. 1998-2025, 220 multi-game series: one more unit of regular-season streakiness (runs-test z) changes the log-odds of winning the series by +0.09 at equal run differential (CI -0.11 to +0.29). The rolling-window measure agrees (+0.04 per 0.01 SD, CI -0.04 to +0.12).

One-run losses hurt more than blowouts C25, bottom of the 7th

What was said. In the 7th: one-run losses hurt more than blowouts; you have to feel something in a blowout.

How I tested it. For every team-game from 1998 to 2025, I compared next-game win % with what team strength, the next opponent and home field predict, by the previous result: a win, a one-run loss, a 2-5 run loss or a loss by 6+. I also asked whether a team's runs in a blowout loss predict its runs the next day any differently than runs in other games.

Right if. One-run losers fall further below expected than blowout losers. *Data: Retrosheet 1998-2025.*

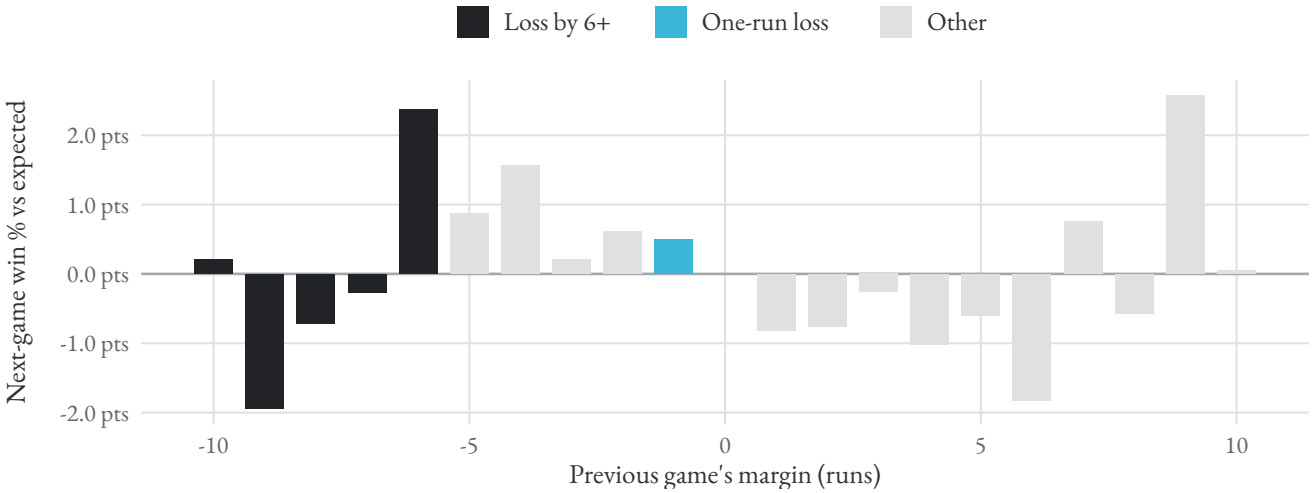


Figure 27: Next-game win % vs expected, by the previous game's margin, 1998-2025.

What I found. Neither kind of loss hurts. After a one-run loss and after a blowout, teams win their next game at the same rate as expected (both about a point above, which is ordinary noise around team strength). Runs scored in a blowout loss predict the next day's offense about as well as runs in any other game.

Caveats. Daily lineups and starters change, and the expected win % is season-level team strength; neither would hide a real gap between the two kinds of loss.

Verdict: Not supported. 1998-2025: next-game win % vs after a win, at equal team strength and home field: +1.1 pts after a one-run loss, +1.1 pts after a loss by 6+; one-run minus blowout = +0.1 pts (CI -1.0 pts to +1.2 pts). Runs scored in a blowout loss predict next-game runs slightly more than runs in other games (+0.024 per run).

Takeaway. Nothing here carries over. Losses of any kind, streaky seasons and bullpen strength do not predict the next game or the series once team quality is known. Stranded runners return to normal, not above it. (Smoltz: 1 of 6 supported or partly supported.)

Part 4

ABS challenges

When to spend the challenge.

Don't use an ABS challenge early in the game, even if you're right C15, bottom of the 3rd

What was said. In the bottom of the 3rd: don't use your ABS challenge early in the game, even if you are right.

How I tested it. From every 2026 regular-season challenge (7,899), I worked out three things: whether a team keeps its challenge after winning one (from the challenges-remaining count before and after), the run value of a won challenge (the difference between a ball and a strike at that count), and, generously to Smoltz, the option value of holding one (every run a team later gained from winning challenges, as if all of it depended on the one held). I also checked my own rule of thumb for catchers: challenge only with 65% or more of the ball in the zone.

Right if. Expected value of holding beats the value of a correct early overturn. *Data: StatsAPI ABS challenges 2026.*

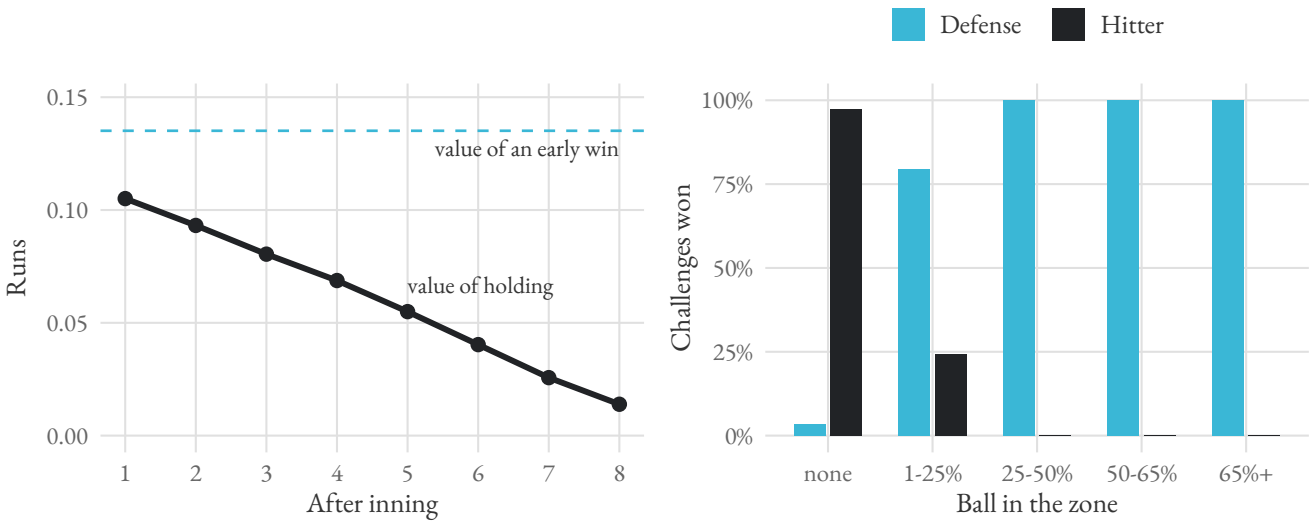


Figure 28: Left: runs a held challenge could still earn after each inning (generous upper bound) vs the average early win. Right: share of challenges won by how much of the ball was in the zone.

What I found. Backwards. A winning challenge is kept (every time, in the data), so a challenge you are right about costs nothing to use, early or late. Even counting every later win as riding on the one held, holding a challenge past the 3rd is worth less than what an early win gains, so an early challenge pays off whenever it wins more than about 37% of the time. Early challenges actually won about 63%. My 65% rule never lost, but defensive challenges with even a quarter of the ball in the zone won every time.

Caveats. Runs are not leverage: a late-inning overturn in a close game is worth more than its run value. That would make holding a bit more valuable than shown, but not enough to justify passing on a challenge you are sure of, which costs nothing.

Verdict: Contradicted. 2026 regular season, 7,899 challenges. A winning challenge is kept (100% of the time in the data), so a correct challenge costs nothing: early in the game it gains 0.135 runs on average and gives up none. Even counting every later winning challenge as lost, holding one past the 3rd is worth only 0.080 runs, so an early challenge pays off whenever it wins more than 37% of the time; early challenges actually won 63%. My rule (defense, 65%+ of the ball in the zone) won 100% of 613; it is safe but conservative, since defensive challenges with 25%+ of the ball in the zone won 100.0% of 1662.

Takeaway. Holding a challenge you would win is a mistake under the 2026 rules, since a winning challenge is kept. My 65 percent rule never lost, but a quarter of the ball in the zone was already enough. (Smoltz: 0 of 1 supported or partly supported.)

Part 5

Platooning the starter

Smoltz's anti-platoon view: is it worth stacking the lineup against the starter's hand, as the Rays did in Game 3?

Smoltz, anti-platoon: platooning against the starter does not pay; the Rays platoon to beat the starter early and shorten his outing C05, bottom of the 1st

What was said. In the bottom of the 1st, on the Rays' lineup: Smoltz came across as anti-platoon, as if stacking the lineup against the starter's hand to beat him early (and keep the opponent's high-leverage relievers out) does not pay.

How I tested it. Three steps, 2023-26 regular season. (a) Is the platoon edge against starters real? The same hitter facing the same starter, with and without the platoon advantage (switch hitters dropped). (b) Does stacking pay? Within a team-season and against the same starter, does a lineup with more platoon-advantage PAs score more off him and get him out sooner? (c) Context: how much the Rays platoon compared with the league, and whether a team trailing after five holds back its top late-lead relievers.

Right if. Smoltz is right if the platoon edge against starters is absent or lineups stacked against the starter's hand do not score more or shorten his outing. Contradicted if the edge is real AND stacked lineups score more off the starter (CIs exclude zero). I corrected my first reading of the note on 2026-10-26. *Data: Statcast 2023-26 regular season.*

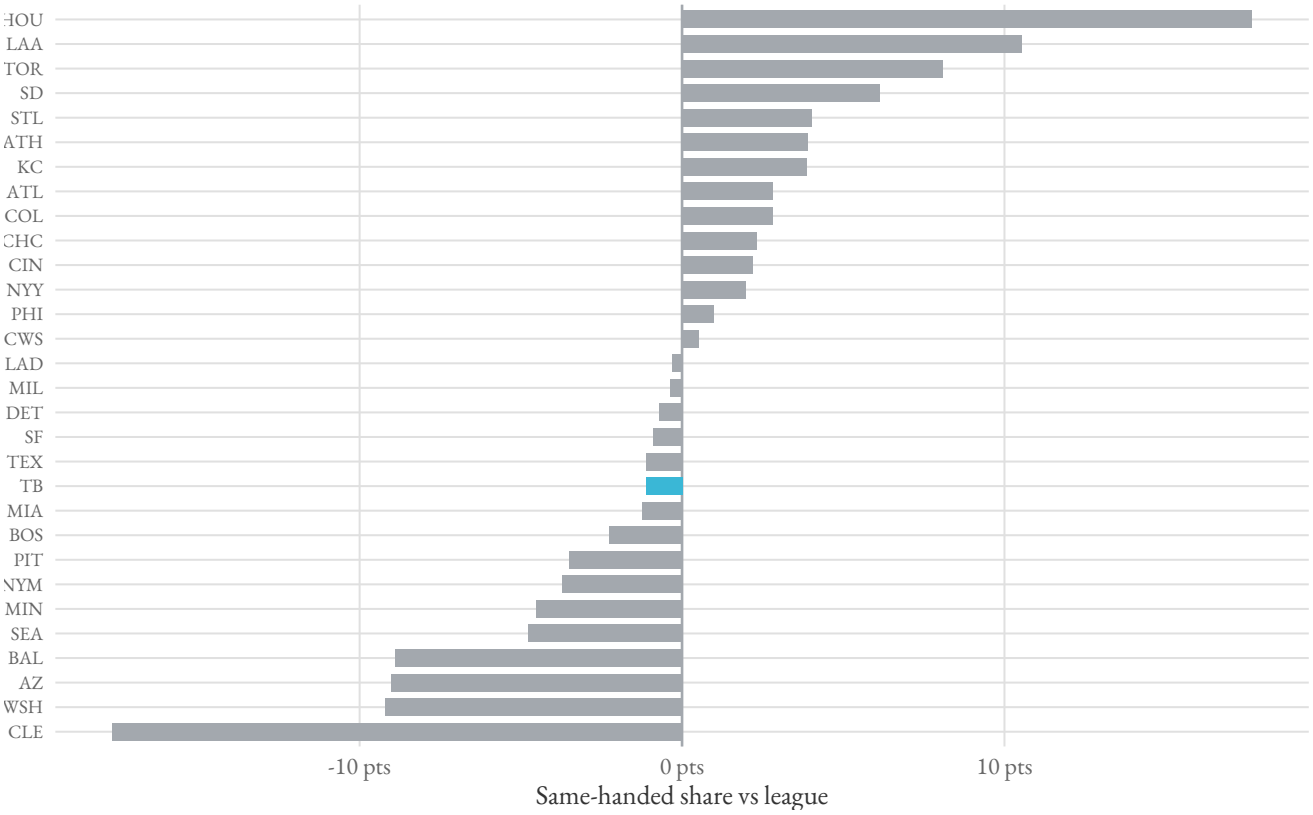


Figure 29: Share of PAs against starters with the same-handed (no platoon edge) matchup, 2023-26, relative to the league. The Rays are highlighted.

What I found. Platooning the starter pays. The same hitter gains about .029 wOBA against the same starter with the platoon edge, and lineups stacked against a starter's hand get him out of the game sooner and score a little more off him. The second half of the idea is also real: teams trailing by 1-3 after five use their top late-lead relievers far less often. The

Rays themselves are not unusual; they platoon about as much as the average team.

Caveats. I misread my note at first and tested whether the Rays are anti-platoon (they are not). Smoltz was the anti-platoon one, so this version tests his view. The runs effect in (b) is small and only just clears zero; the outs effect is clearer.

Verdict: Contradicted. (a) Against starters, the same hitter facing the same starter hits +0.029 wOBA with the platoon advantage (CI +0.025 to +0.034). (b) Within a team-season and against the same starter, 10 more points of platoon-advantage PAs score +0.03 more runs off him (CI +0.00 to +0.05) and change his outs recorded by -0.09 (CI -0.14 to -0.05). (c) The Rays are not unusual: 39.7% of their PAs vs starters came without the platoon edge, -1.1 pts vs the league (rank 20 of 30 for same-handed share); in Game 3 it was 21% against Robert Gasser. Trailing teams do hold back their top late-lead relievers (-27.6 pts vs tied or leading).

Takeaway. Platooning the starter pays. The edge is real, and lineups stacked against the starter's hand score a bit more off him and chase him sooner. The Rays platoon about as much as the average team. (Smoltz: 0 of 1 supported or partly supported.)

Part 6

Freddy Peralta

My question from the 4th inning.

Freddy Peralta's VAA and HAA changed from the Mets to the Rays T01, top of the 4th, my question

What was said. My question from the 4th: did Freddy Peralta's fastball approach angles change from the Mets to the Rays?

How I tested it. All of Peralta's 2026 four-seamers (Statcast, plus Game 3 from the StatsAPI feed), with vertical and horizontal approach angles computed at the front of the plate from the pitch trajectory. Angles depend on where the pitch is located, so I adjusted for plate location and compared the Rays stint with the Mets stint, against the normal month-to-month drift within a team.

Right if. Location-adjusted VAA or HAA shifts beyond month-to-month noise. *Data: Statcast 2026.*

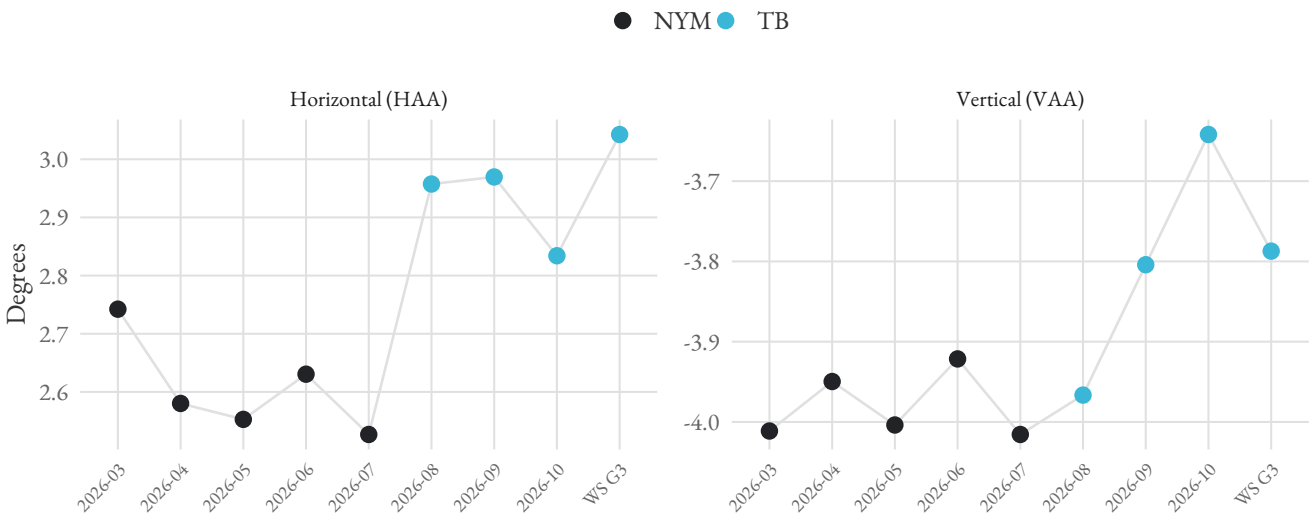


Figure 30: Peralta's location-adjusted four-seam approach angles by month, 2026.

What I found. Yes, horizontally. His location-adjusted horizontal angle moved about +0.36 degrees after the trade, several times the month-to-month noise, and the release point explains it: he lets go about 0.38 feet further to the side with the Rays. He is also throwing about 1.3 mph harder. The vertical angle moved less (+0.16 degrees, under twice the month-to-month spread), not enough to call a change.

Caveats. 22 games with the Mets and 15 with the Rays; October includes postseason starts, where effort is higher.

Verdict: Supported. 2026 four-seamers, location-adjusted, Rays minus Mets: VAA +0.16 degrees and HAA +0.36 degrees, vs a month-to-month spread of 0.10 and 0.05 within a team. Release height -0.03 ft, release side -0.38 ft, extension +0.16 ft, velocity +1.3 mph. The HAA shift is bigger than normal month-to-month drift.

Takeaway. Peralta's fastball comes in at a different horizontal angle with the Rays, and the release point explains it.

Part 7

Steep swings, direction and whiffs

Smoltz's line in the 6th was that the middle/opposite-field approach is the anti-launch-angle approach, and that the launch-angle approach whiffs too much. C21 confirmed the outcome: middle/oppo hitters whiff less. Here I ask why, using bat tracking on 918,415 swings from 2024–26 (970 hitter-seasons with 300+ swings and 150+ balls in play).

A measurement trap first

Swing by swing, whiffs climb steeply with the attack angle Savant records. But on a miss the bat never meets the ball: the angle is read wherever the bat happened to be in its arc when the ball passed, and a fooled swing (early or late) reads steep by construction. So I took every hitter's swing traits (attack angle, tilt, contact depth, bat direction) from his *contact* swings only (fouls and balls in play), and his whiff rate from all of his swings.

Middle/oppo hitters swing flatter, and that is the whole whiff gap

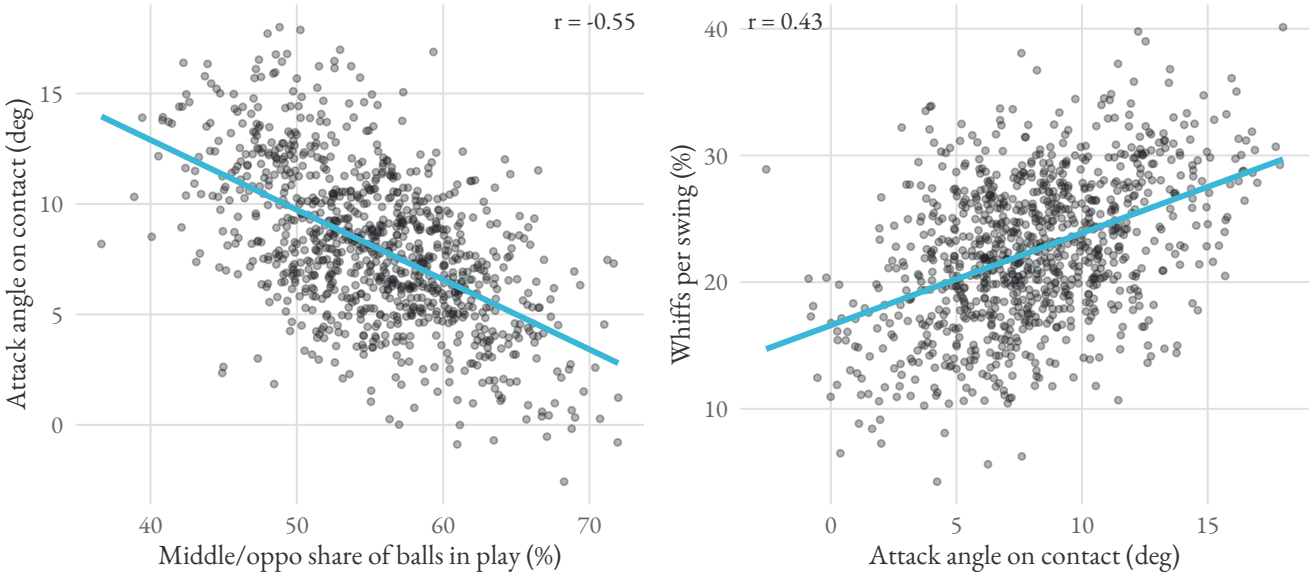


Figure 31: Hitter-seasons, 2024-26. Left: share of balls in play to the middle or opposite field vs usual attack angle on contact. Right: usual attack angle vs whiffs per swing.

The chain is the one Smoltz described. Hitters who spray the ball to the middle and the opposite field swing flatter (r = -0.55), meet the ball deeper (r = -0.32 with how far out front they make contact) and with the bat headed the other way (r = -0.62 with pull-side bat direction). Flatter swings whiff less (r = 0.43), and a steeper attack angle goes with a higher launch angle (r = 0.55): the launch-angle approach is literally the steep swing.

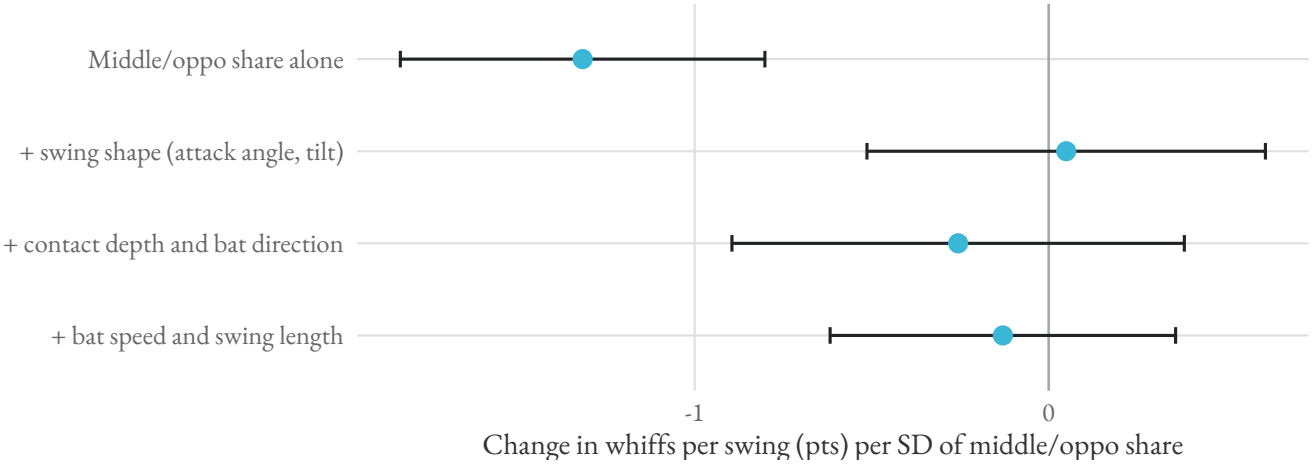


Figure 32: Whiffs per swing for one standard deviation more middle/oppo contact, as more of the swing is held equal. Bars are 95% confidence intervals.

On its own, one standard deviation more middle/oppo contact goes with -1.3 points of whiffs per swing. Hold the swing's angle and tilt equal and it falls to 0.0 (CI -0.5 to 0.6): the direction itself buys nothing. The whiff edge of the middle/oppo hitter *is* his flatter swing.

Where steep swings pay: up in the zone

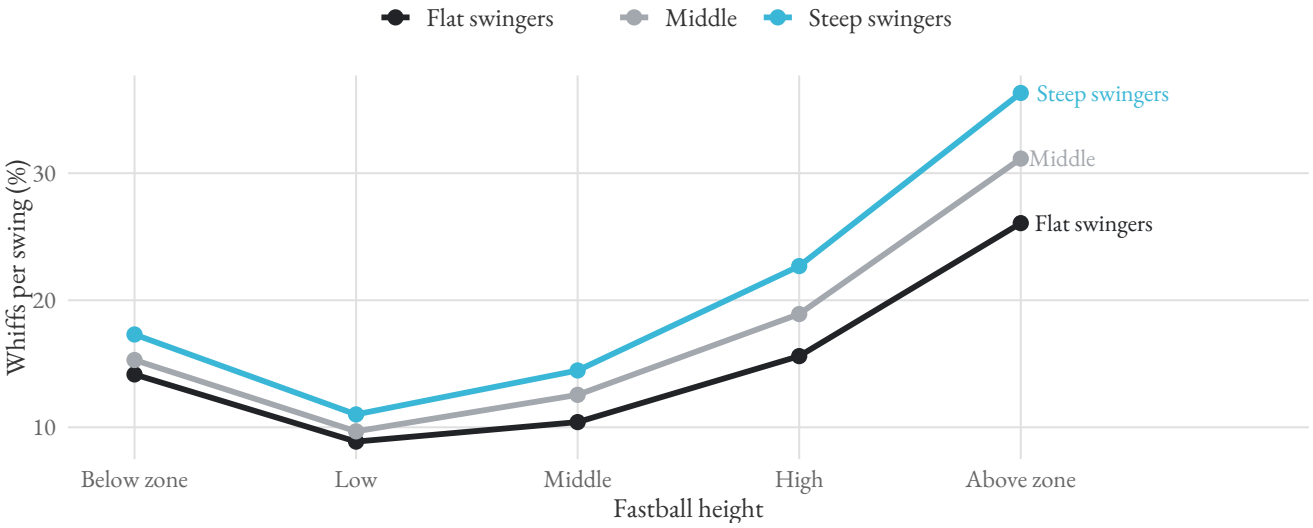


Figure 33: Whiffs per swing on fastballs by pitch height (relative to each hitter's zone) and by hitter swing type (thirds of usual attack angle on contact).

Steep swingers whiff more on fastballs at every height, but the gap grows as the pitch rises: 3.1 points below the zone, 7.1 high in the zone and 10.2 above it. An uppercut swing passes under the high fastball.

Plane matching: the pitch matters, the match does not

A common coaching idea is that a swing should match the plane of the pitch: a steep swinger should handle a steeply falling pitch and struggle with a flat one, and the reverse for a flat swinger. Within the same hitter, at the same location, pitch type, count and velocity, a pitch that falls one degree more than usual for its spot changes whiffs by -1.2 points (CI -1.4 to -1.0): flat pitches beat everyone. But the interaction with the hitter's own swing angle is 0.00 points (CI -0.11 to 0.12), essentially zero. In-zone fastballs that come in flatter than usual for their spot raise whiffs from 9% to 15% for flat swingers and from 12% to 20% for steep swingers: the same penalty, on top of the steep swinger's higher base.

The trade-off

Table 2: Hitter-seasons by swing angle (thirds) and direction (thirds), 2024-26. Run value per swing counts whiffs, fouls and balls in play; it leaves out takes.

Approach	Hitters	Whiff/swing	Launch angle	Barrel/BIP	xwOBA on contact	Runs/100 swings
Steep Middle/oppo	42	25.6%	14.5	10.9%	0.403	-2.05
Steep Pull	187	25.6%	17.3	10.2%	0.383	-2.20
Flat Middle/oppo	177	19.4%	10.3	6.1%	0.352	-2.38
Flat Pull	44	21.1%	13.1	6.3%	0.345	-2.79

Smoltz is right that the launch-angle swing costs whiffs: steep swingers miss about 5 points more often. They earn it back on contact, with roughly 1.7 times the barrel rate and better results per swing. With bat speed held equal, one standard deviation steeper is worth +0.13 runs per 100 swings ($p = 0.02$), while direction adds nothing once angle is known (+0.06). Bat speed is worth far more than either (+0.45 per standard deviation).

> **Takeaway.** Smoltz has the mechanism right: middle/opposite-field hitting and the flat swing are the same approach, and the flat swing is why those hitters whiff less. Where the steep swing loses is the high fastball. The whiffs are a price, not a mistake: the steep swing pays it back in damage, and hitting the ball the other way adds nothing on its own once the swing is accounted for.

Data

Table 3: Data on the drive.

Source	Where	Years	Use
Retrosheet parsed plays	MLB Data/retrosheet/plays	1998-2025	Game, series and base-out claims; pickoff throws from pitch strings
Statcast (raw Savant chunks)	MLB Data/<yr>/MLB/*.parquet	2020-2026 (through WS Game 2)	Pitch-level claims, Peralta, Rays lineups, 2026 records
StatsAPI ABS pitches	abs_challenge_approach/pitches.rds	2026 regular season	Challenge value and success by zone
StatsAPI live feed	game 849804 (World Series Game 3)	2026-10-26	Bauers' 3-0 count, Peralta's Game 3 fastballs
Savant sprint speed	MLB Data/leaderboards/sprint_speed	2018-2026	Runner speed (C06, C07)

Postseason windows: the 12-team format (2022 on) for claims about today's playoffs, as my notes asked; 1998 on (30-team era) when a claim needs more Octobers than four. Rebuild everything with `Rscript scripts/run_all.R` (about 8 minutes).